

Bengali, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Bengali one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Bengali letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read নমস্কার *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Bengali simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi, from Sanskrit — and the mother tongue of Bengal: West Bengal in India and all of Bangladesh, some 250 million speakers, the seventh-largest language on earth. It is the language of Tagore, and the only one to have furnished the national anthem of *two* nations. One habit runs through the whole book and is worth stating up front: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô** (not “a”), its *s* tilts to **sh**, and its *v* collapses to **b** — so Sanskrit *namaskāra* is spoken *nômoshkar*. Learn to hear that shift and every Sanskrit-derived word becomes legible. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Bengali out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Bengali, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

Complete BN-C01-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: greet someone in Bengali, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

1.1 নমস্কার (nômoshkar) — “hello”

The first Bengali word — and it hides the single sound-shift that makes Bengali *Bengali*.

The letters in this word

(If you already read Bengali, skim this.) Bengali runs **left to right** under a top line; every consonant carries a built-in vowel — but in Bengali that vowel is **ô** (an open “o”), *not* “a.” ন nô, ম mô, ক kô, র rô. A **vowel sign** changes it (া ā); a *hasanta* under জ strips its vowel so it joins the next as a conjunct: জ + ক → জ্জ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নমস্কার is the *same word* as the Sanskrit *namaskāra* behind Hindi’s and Marathi’s greeting — *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“the making of”). But hear what Bengali does: the inherent “a” becomes **ô**, and *s* shifts to **sh**, so written *namaskāra* is spoken **nô · mosh · kar**. That habit —

$a \rightarrow \hat{o}$, $s \rightarrow sh$ — is Bengali’s fingerprint; once you hear it, you can un-shift almost any word back to its Sanskrit cousin.

Why it’s said this way

Nômoshkar, palms together, is the everyday respectful greeting — hello and often goodbye — the broad, secular-to-Hindu default in Bengal. Bengali is the language of Tagore, the only tongue to have written the national anthem of *two* countries: India and Bangladesh.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read it — nô · mosh · kar
- the two shifts that made *namaskāra* into *nômoshkar* ($a \rightarrow \hat{o}$, $s \rightarrow sh$)

Before you move on

What Sanskrit word is *nômoshkar*, and what two Bengali sound-shifts disguise it? (*Namaskāra*, “the making of a bow”; the inherent $a \rightarrow \hat{o}$ and $s \rightarrow sh$.)

1.2 ধন্যবাদ (dhônyobad) — “thank you”

The same “thank you” Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi use — now watch Bengali reshape it *twice*.

The letters in this word

New: ধ dhô (a breathy *d*), ব bô, দ dô, and the conjunct ন্য (ন n + য y). With the া sign, read ধ · ন্য · বা · দ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ধন্যবাদ = Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the very “thank you” behind Hindi *dhanyavād*. Two Bengali quirks fire at once: the inherent $a \rightarrow \hat{o}$ again (*dhônyobad*), and — because Bengali has **no separate “v,”** only ব *b* — Sanskrit *vāda* is spoken *bad*. *V* becoming *b* is a Bengali signature (think *Bishnu* for *Vishnu*).

Why it's said this way

This is the standard, slightly formal thanks. In warm everyday speech Bengalis often lean on the whole gesture and tone rather than the word — but *dhônyobad* is what you say and write when you mean it plainly. Note how much you already knew: only the *sound* changed, not the roots.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read it — dhô · nyo · bad
- the two shifts hiding *dhanyavāda* here (a→ô, v→b)

Before you move on

Dhônyobad comes from which two Sanskrit parts, and why is the “v” gone? (*Dhanya* “worthy” + *vāda* “saying”; Bengali has no “v,” only *b*.)

1.3 হ্যাঁ / না (hyā / nā) — “yes” and “no”

Two words no conversation survives without — and one is an old cousin of English.

The letters in this word

New: হ hô, the *y-phola* ঙ that glides the sound, and the nasal mark *chandrabindu* ং — a little moon-with-dot that sends the vowel through the nose. না is simply ন + া, *nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হ্যাঁ (*hyā*, “yes”) and না (*nā*, “no”). That “no” rides the ancient negative **na-** — the same Proto-Indo-European *ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *nōn*, and Hindi *nahīn*. Bengali kept it at its shortest, bare *nā*: the family resemblance to English *no* sits right on the surface.

Why it's said this way

The *chandrabindu* (that nasal moon-dot) is everywhere in Bengali and gives the language part of its soft, nasal music. Hear the breath leave through the nose at the end of *hyã* — that mark is doing the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read them — *hyã* / *nā*
- the shared ancestor of Bengali *nā* and English *no* (PIE *ne*)

Before you move on

What does the *chandrabindu* do, and what links Bengali *nā* to English *no*? (It nasalises the vowel; both descend from Proto-Indo-European *ne*, “not.”)

1.4 আচ্ছা (*āchchhā*) — “okay / I see”

The little word that keeps every Bengali conversation moving.

The letters in this word

New: আ — the **independent** vowel *ā*, the shape a word uses when it *starts* with a vowel. (A built-in vowel rides a consonant; a standalone one gets its own letter.) Then the doubled ছ (চ *ch* + ছ *chh*). Read আ · ছা, *ā-chchhā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আচ্ছা (*āchchhā*) is the all-purpose “okay, alright, I see, go on” — a true workhorse of spoken Bengali, from Sanskrit *acchā* (“good, clear”). It is the word a Bengali speaker peppers through speech the way an English speaker says “right... right,” a nod made audible.

Why it's said this way

Note it opens with আ, a *standalone* vowel-letter — your first. This is the other half of how the script handles vowels: attached to a consonant they are little signs (া), but on their own they stand as full

letters (আ). Same sound, two shapes, chosen by position.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read it — ā · chchhā
- why আ is written in full here (the word starts with a vowel)

Before you move on

What does *āchchhā* do in conversation, and why is its first vowel a full letter, not a sign? (It means “okay / I see / go on”; a word-initial vowel takes its standalone form আ.)

1.5 আসি (āshi) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye)

Bengalis do not say “I’m leaving.” They say “I’ll come again.” Here is why.

The letters in this word

New: ঞ again — here truly “sh” — and the ি sign (*i*), which in Bengali is **written before** the consonant it follows but **read after** it. আসি = আ + সি, *ā-shi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আসি (*āshi*) literally means “**I come**,” from the verb *āsā* (“to come,” a Sanskrit root shared with Hindi *ānā*). Yet it is how Bengalis say *goodbye* — never “I’m leaving” (unlucky, too final) but “I’ll come [again]”: আসি, or the fuller *āschhi* (“I am coming”). It is the very same “promise of return” farewell Tamil and Marathi reach for — a whole culture’s optimism folded into one verb.

Why it’s said this way

And notice: *āshi* is “I come” whether a man or a woman says it — Bengali marks **no gender on the verb**. That sets it apart from Marathi (*yeto* m. / *yete* f.) and, in this one respect, makes Bengali’s

verbs simpler than its neighbours’.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- read it — ā · shi (remember ঞ = “sh”)
- what *āshi* literally means and why it means goodbye (“I come” → “I’ll come again”)

Before you move on

Why does “I come” mean goodbye in Bengali, and what does Bengali *not* mark on this verb? (Saying “I’ll come again” avoids the finality of “leaving”; no gender.)

1.6 Chapter 1 — Practice and Recall

No new words. Just the five, mixed and recombined — and the one shift that ties them together.

How to answer — rapid recall

Say these aloud:

- hello / goodbye, palms together — *nômoshkar*
- thank you — *dhônyobad*
- yes and no — *hyã / nã*
- “okay, I see, go on” — *āchchhā*
- goodbye, “I’ll come again” — *āshi*

Grammar lens — the one habit

Bengali’s fingerprint. Un-shift these back to the Sanskrit you know: Say these aloud:

- what is *nômoshkar* in “un-shifted” Sanskrit? (*namaskāra*)

- what became of the “v” in *dhônyobad*? (Bengali has no “v”; *vāda* → *bad*)
- the inherent vowel of every Bengali consonant — “a” or “ô”? (*ô*)

What you’ve built — roots you now carry

- inherent vowel *ô* + *s*→*sh* + *v*→*b* = the Bengali sound-fingerprint
- *nā* (“no”) ↔ English **no** / **not** / **none** (PIE *ne*)
- *āshi* (“I come”) = the “promise of return” goodbye, shared with Tamil & Marathi

Before you move on

A friend parts by saying *āshi*, and you want to answer warmly. What does *āshi* really mean, and what could you say back? (“I’ll come again” — you can answer *āchchhā*, *āshi* — “okay, I’ll come [too],” returning the same optimism.)

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) 👁️ eyes (5) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can introduce myself in Bengali, give my name, and understand the other person’s name.

Complete BN-C02-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: introduce myself in Bengali, give my name, and understand the other person’s name.

2.1 নাম (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The first word of the introduction — and one of the clearest bridges between India and Europe.

The letters in this word

ন (nô) + া̃ (the long-ā sign) + ম (mô) → নাম (nām). Here the long-ā sign overrides the inherent ô, so it is nām, not “nôm.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাম (nām, “name”) ← Sanskrit नामन् (nāman), from Proto-Indo-European *h₃nómn (its final n syllabic) — the *same* ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**), and Greek *onoma*. Bengali nām and English name are cousins from before either language existed — one of the clearest threads tying the Indian and European branches of one family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nām”
- the family — *nām* / English *name* / Latin *nōmen* / Greek *onoma*

Before you move on

What roots is *nām* from, and its English cousins? (Sanskrit *nāman* / PIE **h₃nómn*; **name**, **noun**, **nominate**.)

2.2 আমার (āmār) — “my”

The little word that makes the name *yours*.

The letters in this word

আ (the independent long *ā*, used because the word starts with a vowel) + মা (*mā*) + র (*r*) → আমার (*āmār*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমার (*āmār*, “my”) is the possessive of আমি (*āmi*, “I”), on the first-person stem **ām-** ← Sanskrit *asmad* (the “we/I” stem). Buried in it is the same ancient first-person **m-** that runs through English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē* — so Bengali’s “my” and English’s “my” share, at the root, one first-person sound.

Grammar Lens: no gender here

Note something Bengali does *not* do: আমার never changes for gender. Hindi and Punjabi have *merā* (m.) / *merī* (f.); Bengali has just **āmār**, for a man or a woman, a masculine or feminine thing. Bengali threw grammatical gender away entirely — you will see this again and again, and it makes Bengali, in this one respect, simpler than its western cousins.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmār”
- its owner (*āmi*, “I”)
- does it change for a man vs. a woman? (No — Bengali has no gender)

Before you move on

What is *āmār* the possessive of, and how does it differ from Hindi’s *merā*? (*Āmi*, “I”; *āmār* never changes for gender, where *merā/merī* does.)

2.3 আমার নাম ... (*āmār nām ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

Assemble the two atoms — and notice a whole word English needs that Bengali drops.

The two words — assembled

আমার (my) + নাম (name) + your name → আমার নাম ... = “my name ...”
→ “my name is...” *Āmār nām Arun.* → “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens: Bengali drops “is” in the present

Look at what is missing: there is **no verb**. Bengali sets “my name” beside “Arun” — *āmār nām Arun* — and the “is” is simply understood. This is the **zero copula**: for present-tense equational sentences (X is Y), Bengali needs no “to be” at all. (It is the same habit Tamil has — and unlike Hindi’s *merā nām ... hai*, which keeps the *hai*.) Bengali only brings back a verb when it talks about a *state* or *place* — you’ll see that in Chapter 3.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmār nām ...” with your name
- notice — no word for “is”

Before you move on

Give your name in Bengali, and say what it leaves out that English requires. (*Āmār nām*; the verb “is” — the zero copula.)

2.4 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো (*ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*) — “pleased to meet you”

The warm close of an introduction.

The letters in this word

The key word is আলাপ (*ālāp*): আ + লা (*lā*) + প (*p*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো = আলাপ (*ālāp*, “acquaintance, conversation”) + করে (*kore*, “having done”) + ভালো লাগলো (*bhālo lāglo*, “[it] felt good”) — literally “**having made your acquaintance, [it] felt good.**” The key word আলাপ (*ālāp*) is Sanskrit — *ālāpa* (“conversing, addressing,” from *ā-* “toward” + *lap* “to speak”), the same *ālāp* that names the slow opening section of a *rāga* in Indian classical music, where the musician “converses” with the notes. So even a hello leans on Sanskrit’s word for the meeting of two voices.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*”
- what *ālāp* means, and where else you’ve heard it (acquaintance/conversation; the *ālāp* of a *rāga*)

Before you move on

What does the phrase literally say, and what is *ālāp*? (“Having made [your] acquaintance, it felt good”; Sanskrit *ālāpa*, “conversing” — as in a *rāga*’s opening.)

2.5 কি (ki) — “what”

The question-word — and it starts with the **k-** that heads nearly every Bengali question.

The letters in this word

ক (*kô*) + ি (the *i*-sign, written **before** the consonant but read after) → কি (*ki*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কি (*ki*, “what”) ← Sanskrit *kim* / the interrogative stem **ka-**, from PIE ***k^wo-** — the same question-root behind English **wh-** words (**what**, **who**, **which**) and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with this **k-**: *ki* (what), *ke* (who), *kôbe* (when), *kôthāy* (where), *kēmon* (how). Learn the *k-* and you can hear a question coming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ki”
- the *k-* question family — *ki*, *ke*, *kôbe*, *kôthāy*, *kēmon*

Before you move on

What root do Bengali’s question-words share, and its English family? (The interrogative *k-*, PIE ***k^wo-**; the *wh-* words.)

2.6 তুমি / আপনি (tumi / āpni) — “you,” three ways

To ask a name you need “you” — and Bengali grades it **three** ways.

The letters in this word

তুমি (*tumi*): তু (*tu*) + মি (*mi*). আপনি (*āpni*): আ + প + নি.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

তুমি (*tumi*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE **tū* — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. Bengali grades respect in **three** levels:

- তুই (*tui*) — intimate: close friends, children, family.
- তুমি (*tumi*) — familiar: friends, juniors, warmth.
- আপনি (*āpni*) — respectful: elders, strangers, formality.

(This is like Hindi’s *tū* / *tum* / *āp*, and finer than the two-way split of the Romance tracks.) For a first meeting, use আপনি.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three — *tui* (intimate) / *tumi* (familiar) / *āpni* (respectful)
- the English cousin of *tumi* (**thou**)
- which you use on first meeting (*āpni*)

Before you move on

Name Bengali’s three “you”s, and which English pronoun *tumi* is cousin to. (*Tui* / *tumi* / *āpni*; archaic **thou**.)

2.7 তোমার নাম কি? (tomār nām ki?) — “what’s your name?”

Turn the introduction around — ask, instead of tell.

The two words — assembled

তোমার (*tomār*, “your,” from *tumi*) + নাম (name) + কি (what) → literally “**your name what?**” And note — still **no “is.”** The zero copula holds here too: Bengali simply lays “your name” beside “what,” and the question is complete.

Grammar Lens: answering, and the respectful form

Answer with the sentence you built: *Āmār nām Arun*. The respectful version swaps *tomār* (from *tumi*) for **আপনার** (*āpnār*, “your,” from *āpni*): *āpnār nām ki?* — the one to use with a stranger.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the familiar question — *tomār nām ki?*
- the respectful version — *āpnār nām ki?*
- answer it — *āmār nām ...*

Before you move on

Ask “what’s your name?” respectfully, and note what’s still missing. (*Āpnār nām ki?*; there is no word for “is” — the zero copula.)

2.8 Chapter 2 — The introduction exchange

No new words. The whole introduction, assembled from atoms you now own.

The exchange

Say these aloud:

- “My name is Mira.” — *āmār nām Mira*.
- “What’s your name?” (respectful) — *āpnār nām ki?*
- “My name is Arun.” — *āmār nām Arun*.
- “Pleased to meet you.” — *ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Say these aloud:

- “name,” “my” (*nām*, *āmār*)

- the three “you” levels (*tui* / *tumi* / *āpni*)
- “what,” and the word Bengali leaves out (*ki*; there is no “is”)

What you’ve built — roots you now carry

- *nām* ← Sanskrit *nāman* → English **name**
- *āmār* ← the first-person *ām-*; no gender (unlike Hindi *merā*/*merī*)
- *ki* ← *ka-* → English **what**; *tumi* ← **tū* → **thou**
- *ālāp* ← Sanskrit *ālāpa*, “conversing”

Before you move on

Introduce yourself and ask a stranger’s name in Bengali — and note the one word you never say. (*Āmār nām Āpnār nām ki?* — no word for “is.”)

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is in Bengali, answer naturally, and return the question.

Complete BN-C03-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: ask how someone is in Bengali, answer naturally, and return the question.

3.1 আমি (āmi) — “I,” cousin of English *am*

To answer “how are you?” you first need “I” — and it hides the English word *am*.

The letters in this word

আ (independent long *ā*) + মি (*mi*) → আমি (*āmi*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমি (*āmi*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit अस्मि (*asmi*, “I am”), on the first-person stem *asmad*. That Sanskrit *asmi* is from Proto-Indo-European ***h₁es-**, the “to be” root — the very same word that gives English **am** (and Latin *sum*). So Bengali’s word for “I” is, at the root, a form of “**am**”: “I” and “am” were once one word. Its possessive is the আমার (*āmār*, “my”) from Chapter 2.

Grammar Lens: “I” can often be dropped

Bengali verbs carry the person in their ending — *āchhi* already means “I am” — so *āmi* is often left out once it’s clear. You still learn it first, because the answer to *kēmon āchho?* begins with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmi”
- the pair — *āmi* (I), *āmār* (my)
- the English cousin hidden in it (*am* — from the same *asmi*)

Before you move on

What Sanskrit word is *āmi* from, and its English cousin? (*Asmi*, “I am”; English **am** — same PIE root **h₁es-*.)

3.2 কেমন (kēmon) — “how,” another of the k-questions

You met কি (*ki*, “what”) in Chapter 2. Here is its sibling.

The letters in this word

কে (*kē*, *kô* + the *e*-sign) + মন (*mon*) → কেমন (*kēmon*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কেমন (*kēmon*, “how, of what kind”) is from the interrogative stem **ka-**, from PIE ***k^wo-** — the same question-root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with this **k-**: *ki* (what), *ke* (who), *kôbe* (when), *kôthāy* (where), *kēmon* (how). It is the Indian branch of the same family of question-words that gave English *what/who/how*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kēmon”
- the k- question family — *ki, ke, kôbe, kôthāy, kēmon*

Before you move on

What root do Bengali’s question-words share, and its English family? (The interrogative *k-*, PIE **k^wo-*; the *wh-* words.)

3.3 তুমি কেমন আছো? (tumi kēmon āchho?) — “how are you?”

The everyday “how are you?” — and the first time Bengali brings back a verb “to be.”

The letters in this word

The new word is আছো (*āchho*, “are you”), from the verb আছা (*āchhā*, “to be, to exist, to have”) + the familiar-you ending -ও (-o). Note the ছ (*chh*) — a breathy *ch*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

তুমি কেমন আছো? = তুমি (*tumi*, familiar “you”) + কেমন (*kēmon*, “how”) + আছো (*āchho*, “are”) — “you how are?”, the verb **last**.

Grammar Lens: now the copula returns

In Chapter 2, Bengali dropped “is”: *āmār nām Arun* (“my name Arun”). That **zero copula** works for *equations* (X is Y). But “how are you?” asks about a **state** — how you *exist* — and for that Bengali uses a real verb, আছা (*āchhā*). So: no verb for “my name is Arun,” a real verb for “how are you.” Respectful form: আপনি কেমন আছেন? (*āpni kēmon āchhen?* — *āchhen* for *āpni*). Match the “you” to the verb-ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the familiar question — *tumi kēmon āchho?*
- the respectful version — *āpni kēmon āchhen?*
- why here Bengali needs a verb but “my name is Arun” didn’t (state vs. equation)

Before you move on

What verb does “how are you?” use, and why does this need one when “my name is Arun” didn’t? (*Āchhā*, “to be/exist”; it describes a state, not an equation — the zero copula only covers X is Y.)

3.4 ভালো (bhālo) — “well,” and how to answer

The word that answers “how are you?” — and one Bengalis say all the time.

The letters in this word

ভা (*bhā*, an aspirated *b* + long *ā*) + লো (*lo*) → ভালো (*bhālo*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভালো (*bhālo*, “good, well, fine”) is the everyday Bengali “good” — likely from Sanskrit भद्र (*bhadra*, “good, auspicious, gentle”), worn down over centuries into *bhālo*. It is one of the most-used words in the language: *bhālo lāge* (“[I] like it”), *bhālobāsā* (“love,” literally “good-dwelling”).

The exchange — the reply

With the *āchhā* verb: আমি ভালো আছি (*āmi bhālo āchhi*) — “I am well” (*āchhi* = “I am/exist”). The whole exchange:

— *tumi kēmon āchho?* (“How are you?”) — *āmi bhālo āchhi, dhōnnobad.* (“I’m well, thank you.”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhālo”
- the full reply — *āmi bhālo āchhi*
- the tender word built on it (*bhālobāsā*, “love”)

Before you move on

Give the full reply to *tumi kēmon āchho?*, and name *bhālo*’s likely Sanskrit source. (*Āmi bhālo āchhi*; Sanskrit *bhadra*, “good.”)

3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না (kono bāpār nā) — “no matter”

When someone thanks you — or apologises — this is the easy, gracious reply, and it reuses a word from Chapter 1.

The letters in this word

কোনো (*kono*, “any”) + ব্যাপার (*bāpār*, “matter, affair” — with the *ya-phola* on ব্য) + না (*nā*, “no/not,” from Chapter 1) → *kono bāpār nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কোনো ব্যাপার না literally means “[it’s] **no matter**” — *kono* (“any”) + *bāpār* (“matter, affair”) + *nā* (“not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / no worries / never mind / you’re welcome.” The word ব্যাপার (*bāpār*, “matter, affair, business”) is **Sanskrit** — *vyāpāra* (“occupation, dealing”). And না (*nā*) you met in Chapter 1: the ancient negative, PIE ***ne**, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**. So the reply pairs a Sanskrit noun with the oldest negative in the family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kono bāpār nā”

- what it literally means (“[it’s] no matter”)
- the exchange — *dhônnobad* / *kono bəpār nā*

Before you move on

What does *kono bəpār nā* literally say, and which Chapter-1 word does it reuse? (“It’s no matter”; *nā*, “not” — PIE **ne*, English *no*.)

3.6 Chapter 3 — The how-are-you exchange

No new words. The whole responding cycle, from atoms you now own.

The exchange

Say these aloud:

- “How are you?” (familiar) — *tumi kēmon āchho?*
- “I’m well, thank you.” — *āmi bhālo āchhi, dhônnobad.*
- “No matter / you’re welcome.” — *kono bəpār nā.*
- the respectful question — *āpni kēmon āchhen?*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Say these aloud:

- the k- question-word for “how” (*kēmon*)
- “I” and the verb “to be/exist” (*āmi*, *āchhā*)
- when Bengali needs the verb and when it drops it (state vs. equation)

What you’ve built — roots you now carry

- *kēmon* ← the interrogative *k-* (PIE **k^wo-*), cousin of English *how/what*
- *āmi* ← Sanskrit *asmī*, cousin of English **am**

- *bhālo* ← Sanskrit *bhadra* “good”; *āmi bhālo āchhi* “I’m well”
- *nā* ← PIE **ne*, English *no* (in *kono bəpār nā*)

Before you move on

A stranger asks *āpni kēmon āchhen?* — give a full, polite reply, and answer their thanks. (*Āmi bhālo āchhi, dhōnnobad* — and to thanks, *kono bəpār nā.*)

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (3) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a Bengali conversation politely and choose a farewell that fits the situation.

Complete BN-C04-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: end a Bengali conversation politely and choose a farewell that fits the situation.

4.1 আবার (ābār) — “again,” the seed of “see you again”

One small word turns a goodbye from “farewell” into “**till next time.**”

The letters in this word

আ (independent ā) + বা (bā) + র (r) → আবার (ābār).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আবার (ābār, “again, once more”) is a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar *job*: it turns a parting into a promise. Chapter 1 gave you আসি (āshi, “I’ll come [again]”) as goodbye; add ābār and you can say outright “we’ll meet **again.**”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ābār”
- what it adds to a goodbye (“again”)

Before you move on

What does *ābār* mean, and what does it do to a farewell? (“Again”; it makes the parting a promise of return.)

4.2 দেখা হবে (dækhā hōbe) — “(we) will meet”

A future-tense phrase — the other half of “see you again,” built in a way English never would.

The letters in this word

দেখা (dækhā, “seeing”) = দে (dæ) + খা (khā). হবে (hōbe, “will be/happen”) = হ (hō) + বে (be).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা হবে literally means “[a] seeing will happen” — dækhā (the noun “seeing,” from দেখা dækhā “to see”) + hōbe (“will be/happen,” the future of হওয়া hōwā, “to be, to become”). Bengali says “a meeting will occur” rather than “we will meet” — an impersonal, gentle way to promise reunion. The verb হওয়া hōwā (“to be/become”) is the same one behind āchhā’s cousin, and its root ভূ / হ ties (distantly) to English **be**.

Grammar Lens: the impersonal future

Many Bengali “we’ll...” expressions use this **noun + hōbe** (“...will happen”) shape: dækhā hōbe (“[a] seeing will happen”), kôthā hōbe (“[a] talk will happen”). No “we,” no active verb — the event itself is the subject.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*dækhā hôbe*”
- its literal meaning (“[a] seeing will happen”)
- the verb “to see” inside it (*dækhā*)

Before you move on

What does *dækhā hôbe* literally say, and what is odd (to English ears) about it? (“A seeing will happen”; it is impersonal — the *event* is the subject, not “we.”)

4.3 আবার দেখা হবে (*ābār dækhā hôbe*) — “we’ll meet again”

The warm, everyday goodbye — the fuller cousin of Chapter 1’s *āshi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আবার দেখা হবে = আবার (*ābār*, “again”) + দেখা হবে (*dækhā hôbe*, “[a] seeing will happen”) — “**we’ll meet again**” (literally “again a seeing will happen”). Chapter 1 gave you the tender আসি (*āshi*, “I’ll come [again]”), the “promise of return” goodbye; *ābār dækhā hôbe* is its warm, explicit form. It is the sibling of the whole subcontinent’s parting habit (Hindi *phir milenge*, Tamil *pōy varugirēn*): never a blunt “goodbye,” always a return promised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the warm goodbye — *ābār dækhā hôbe*
- the two pieces (*ābār* + *dækhā hôbe*)
- the Chapter-1 goodbye it deepens (*āshi*)

Before you move on

What does *ābār dækhā hōbe* literally say, and how does it relate to *āshī*? (“Again a seeing will happen”; it is the fuller, explicit form of Ch.1’s “promise of return” goodbye.)

4.4 কাল দেখা হবে (*kāl dækhā hōbe*) — “see you tomorrow”

A goodbye for tomorrow — built on a word that means both **tomorrow** and **yesterday**.

The letters in this word

কা (*kā*) + ল (*l*) → কাল (*kāl*). Two simple letters, one tricky word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কাল (*kāl*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*, “time”). (It is the very same *kāla* behind Hindi’s *kal* and Punjabi’s *akāl* “timeless.”) Bengali trusts the verb’s tense to tell which: *kāl dækhā hōbe* (future → “**tomorrow**”), *kāl dækhā hōyechhilo* (past → “**yesterday**”). So কাল দেখা হবে = “tomorrow, a seeing will happen” = “see you tomorrow.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kāl dækhā hōbe*”
- the puzzle — *kāl* means both **tomorrow** and **yesterday**
- the root and its cousins (*kāla* “time”; Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*)

Before you move on

What two opposite days does *kāl* mean, and what tells them apart? (Both tomorrow and yesterday; the verb’s tense.)

4.5 Chapter 4 — The farewells

No new words. Three ways to part — none of them a blunt “goodbye.”

Why it’s said this way

Say these aloud:

- the tender Chapter-1 goodbye — *āshi* (“I’ll come [again]”)
- the fuller “we’ll meet again” — *ābār dækhā hôbe*
- “see you tomorrow” — *kāl dækhā hôbe*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Say these aloud:

- “again” and “[a] seeing will happen” (*ābār, dækhā hôbe*)
- the word that means BOTH tomorrow and yesterday (*kāl*)
- what’s odd about *dækhā hôbe* (impersonal — the event is the subject)

What you’ve built — roots you now carry

- *dækhā hôbe* — “[a] seeing will happen”; the impersonal future
- *kāl* ← *kāla* “time” (Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*)
- *āshi* (Ch.1) — “I’ll come [again],” the Bengali promise-of-return goodbye

Before you move on

You’re leaving a friend and expect to see them next week. Which goodbye fits, and how does Bengali phrase “we’ll meet”? (*Ābār dækhā hôbe*; impersonally — “a seeing will happen.”)

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (4) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build short present-tense Bengali sentences with the chapter’s first verbs.

Complete BN-C05-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: build short present-tense Bengali sentences with the chapter’s first verbs.

5.1 বলা (bôlā) — “to speak,” your first full verb

So far, “to be.” Here is a verb that *does* something — and it reveals how gloriously simple Bengali verbs are.

The letters in this word

ব (bô) + লা (lā) → বলা (bôlā). The dictionary form of the verb.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বলা (bôlā, “to speak, to say”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). Its ending -আ (-ā) is Bengali’s infinitive marker. To say “**I speak**,” add the present ending -ই (-i) to the stem: *bôl-* + *-i* → বলি (bôli), “I speak.”

Grammar Lens: the verb changes for person — but *never* for gender

Bengali verbs change ending for **who** speaks: *āmi bôli* (I say), *tumi bôlo* (you say), *se bôle* (he/she says). But — and here is Bengali’s great simplification — the verb **never changes for gender**. There is no “he-form” and “she-form,” no masculine/feminine at all: *se bôle* is “he says” *and* “she says.” Where Hindi and Punjabi make even “I speak” agree with the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*), Bengali dropped grammatical gender entirely. One less thing to track, forever.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bôlā” (to speak)
- “I speak” — *āmi bôli*
- does “he says” differ from “she says”? (No — *se bôle* for both; Bengali has no gender)

Before you move on

What does the Bengali verb change for, and what does it never change for? (For person — *bôli/bôlo/bôle* — but never for gender.)

5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি (*āmi bānglā bôli*) — “I speak Bengali”

Your first complete, moving sentence — and the language’s own name for itself.

The letters in this word

বাংলা (*bānglā*): বা (*bā*) + ং (the *anusvāra* nasal) + লা (*lā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমি বাংলা বলি = আমি (*āmi*, “I”) + বাংলা (*bānglā*, the object) + বলি (*bôli*, “speak”) — “I Bengali speak,” the verb last as always. The name

বাংলা (*bānglā*) is the language’s own word for itself (English “Bengali” comes from it, via *Bangla* → *Bengal*). It descends from বঙ্গ (*bôngo*), the ancient name of the region — so the language is named after its land, the great delta of the Ganges.

Grammar Lens: no gender, so the sentence is the same for anyone

Because Bengali verbs carry no gender, আমি বাংলা বলি is exactly the same whether a man or a woman says it — unlike Hindi (*mainī ... boltā/boltī hūmī*). And because the *-i* ending already means “I,” you could even drop *āmi*: *bānglā bôli* is a complete “I speak Bengali.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmi bānglā bôli”
- what *bānglā* is named after (*bôngo*, the ancient region — the Ganges delta)
- does the sentence change for a man vs. a woman? (No — Bengali has no gender)

Before you move on

Say “I speak Bengali,” and give the origin of the name *bānglā*. (*Āmi bānglā bôli*; from *bôngo*, the ancient name of the Bengal region.)

5.3 কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*) — “to work”

The last verb of the chapter — and, like Hindi’s *karnā*, it is a “do” verb that builds a hundred others.

The letters in this word

কাজ (*kāj*, “work”): কা (*kā*) + জ (*j*). করা (*kôrā*, “do”): ক (*kô*) + রা (*rā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

করা (*kôrā*, “to do, to make”) is from Sanskrit $\sqrt{kr}$ ($\sqrt{kr}$, “to do”), from PIE $*k^wer-$ — the same root you met in Chapter 1’s নমস্কার (*nômoshkar* = *namas* + *kāra*, “the **making** of a bow”) and in *karma*. And কাজ (*kāj*, “work”) is itself from Sanskrit *kārya* (“work, task,” also from $\sqrt{kr}$) — so “work- do” is, at root, “*kr*-thing *kr*-do.” Like Hindi, Bengali builds compound verbs as **noun** + করা:

- কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*) = “work-do” = “**to work**”
- কথা বলা (*kôthā bôlā*) = “to converse” (using *bôlā* from earlier)

So *āmi kāj kôri* = “I work” — the *-i* “I” ending, no gender.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāj kôrā” (to work)
- “I work” — *āmi kāj kôri*
- the Chapter-1 word that shares the $\sqrt{kr}$ root (*nômoshkar*)

Before you move on

What Sanskrit root do both *kôrā* (“do”) and *kāj* (“work”) come from, and name a Chapter-1 word built on it. ($\sqrt{kr}$, “to do”; *nômoshkar* — “the making of a bow.”)

5.4 থাকা (*thākā*) — “to live, to stay”

A second verb, so you can say where you live.

The letters in this word

থা (*thā*, an aspirated *t* + long *ā*) + কা (*kā*) → থাকা (*thākā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

থাকা (*thākā*, “to live, to stay, to remain”) is from Sanskrit स्था (*sthā*, “to stand, to stay”) — the same PIE root ***steh₂-** (“to stand”) that gives English **stand**, **stay**, **state**, and Latin *stāre*. So Bengali’s “to live/stay” and English’s “to stand/stay” are, at the root, one word. “I live in Kolkata” is আমি কলকাতায় থাকি (*āmi Kolkātāy thāki*) — stem *thāk-* + the *-i* “I” ending, no gender.

Grammar Lens: “in” comes after the noun

কলকাতায় (*Kolkātāy*) = *Kolkata* + -য় / -তে (*-y/-te*, “in, at”), glued to the **end** of the noun. Bengali uses **postpositions** (case-endings) where English uses prepositions: “Kolkata-in I live,” the verb last.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thākā”
- “I live in Kolkata” — *āmi Kolkātāy thāki*
- the English cousins of its root *sthā* (*stand*, *stay*, *state*)

Before you move on

What Sanskrit/PIE root is *thākā* from, and its English cousins? (Sanskrit *sthā* / PIE ***steh₂-** “to stand”; English **stand**, **stay**, **state**.)

5.5 Chapter 5 — The first verbs

No new words. Three verbs, one gender-free engine — build real sentences about yourself.

How to answer — build the sentences

Say these aloud:

- “I speak Bengali” — *āmi bānglā bôli*

- “I live in Kolkata” — *āmi Kolkātāy thāki*
- “I work” — *āmi kāj kôri*
- “he speaks” and “she speaks” — *se bôle* (the same for both!)

Grammar lens — the engine

Say these aloud:

- the “I” ending on every present verb (-i)
- the one thing Bengali verbs never mark (gender)
- where the verb sits, and where “in” sits (verb last; -y/-te after the noun)

What you’ve built — roots you now carry

- *bôlā* “to speak” (native; *bol-*, like Hindi/Punjabi)
- *thākā* “to live” ← Sanskrit *sthā* → English **stand/stay/state**
- *kôrā* “to do” ← $\sqrt{\text{kr}}$ — root of *nômoshkar*; *kāj* “work” ← *kārya* (also $\sqrt{\text{kr}}$)
- *bānglā* ← *bôngo*, the ancient region — the Ganges delta

Before you move on

In one breath, say your language, your city, and your work in Bengali — and note what stays the same for anyone. (*Āmi bānglā bôli. Āmi ... thāki. Āmi kāj kôri* — no gender, so it’s the same for a man or a woman.)

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from one to five in Bengali script and say what দুই kept that Hindi and Marathi flattened away.

Count ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch aloud, name the chandrabindu riding পাঁচ, and set দুই beside Hindi do and Marathi don to show the -i it preserved.

6.1 এক, দুই, তিন, চার, পাঁচ — one to five

Bengali writes in its own script, but the words underneath are the same family you'd hear in Delhi or Mumbai — with one number that preserves something both of them lost.

You'll want to know: the five

	Bengali	said
1	এক	<i>ek</i>
2	দুই	<i>dui</i>
3	তিন	<i>tin</i>
4	চার	<i>chār</i>
5	পাঁচ	<i>pāch</i>

The ঁ on *pāch* is the **chandrabindu**, the same moon-dot Hindi uses, nasalising the vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	2
Sanskrit	stem <i>dvá-</i> (masc. <i>dváu</i> , fem./neut. <i>dvé</i>)
Prakrit	<i>do</i> / <i>duve</i>
Hindi	<i>do</i>
Marathi	<i>don</i>
Bengali	<i>dui</i>

Hindi and Marathi flattened the old form into a single *o*. Bengali kept a trace of the following **-i**, which is why it has two syllables where its neighbours have one.

The *dv-* cluster itself is gone from the **numeral** in all of them. (Not from the languages — *dv-* is alive in words borrowed straight back out of Sanskrit, like Bengali দ্বার *dvār* “door.” It’s the everyday inherited word that simplified.)

And Bengali isn’t unique in keeping that vowel: **Assamese, Odia and Nepali** have *dui* too. Among the four languages in this chapter it stands alone; across the eastern Indo-Aryan languages it has plenty of company.

The letters in this word

Bengali’s inherent vowel leans toward **o**, not *a* — which is why the greeting from Chapter 1 is *nomoshkar* where Hindi says *namaskār*. You won’t hear that in these five numbers, as it happens: এক opens with the independent vowel ঐ, and none of the others has a bare inherent-vowel syllable either. Mentioned so you don’t go looking for it here — but keep it in mind the moment a word does have one. Don’t let a neighbouring language’s spelling tell you how Bengali sounds.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch”
- the twos — “dvá- ... do ... don ... **dui**”
- the Ch. 1 echo — “**nomoshkar**, not **namaskār**”

Before you move on

Count to five in Bengali. (*Ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch.*) What does ঐ keep that Hindi and Marathi flattened away? (**The following -i**, which is why it has two syllables.) Is Bengali alone in that? (**No** — Assamese, Odia and Nepali have *dui* too; it's alone only among the four here.) Did the *dv*- cluster survive anywhere in the everyday numeral? (**No** — though *dv*- is alive in words re-borrowed from Sanskrit, like *dvār* “door”.) What is the ঙ? (The **chandrabindu**, nasalising the vowel.) Next: six to ten.

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what I do with six everyday Bengali verbs, pick the ending that matches তুই, তুমি or আপনি, and say why a Bengali verb never changes for gender and why আছে has to hand the future to হবে.

Say āmi jāni and āmi tāke chini, separate জানা from চেনা the way French separates savoir from connaître, hear the vowel harmony that closes chini where chæne stays open, and run the chapter’s six verbs back — hôwā, jāwā, āsā, khāwā, dækhā, jānā.

7.1 হওয়া (hôwā) — “to be,” and the be-verb it stands beside

Chapter 2 said “my name Arun” with no verb at all. Chapter 3 put one back for “how are you.” Both were right, and this verb is why.

You’ll want to know: হওয়া

হওয়া — hôwā — to be, to become

আমি হই (āmi hôi), “I am, I become.” সে হয় (se hôy), “he is.” Its future is already in your mouth: হবে (hôbe) is the “will happen” inside Chapter 4’s dækhā hôbe.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হওয়া is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$, “to become”) with the *bh-* worn down to a plain *h-*: *bhavati* → Prakrit *hoī* → Bengali *hō-*. The root is PIE $*b^h_uH-$, “to grow, to become,” and English owns two of its children outright — **be** and **been**. Latin built *fuī* (“I was”) and *futūrus* on it, which is English **future**; Greek built *phúsis*, “growth, nature,” which is **physics**.

The letters in this word

হ is a soft, breathed *h* carrying Bengali’s inherent vowel — *hō*, not *ha*. ওয়া (*-wā*) is the tail every dictionary-form verb wears; you will meet it again on খাওয়া and যাওয়া.

Grammar Lens: two be-verbs, and one of them is unfinished

what you mean	what Bengali uses
my name is Arun	no verb at all
I have a book; it is here	আছে (<i>āchhe</i>)
he will be a teacher	হবে (<i>hōbe</i>)

আছ-, the verb behind Chapter 3’s *kemon āchho*, means **being present**. But it is unfinished: it has a present and a past, and nothing else at all. Push it into the future and it stops dead — so Bengali picks up হ- (*hōbe*), or Chapter 5’s থাকা (*āmi thākbo*, “I’ll be there”). One job, two verbs, split down the middle.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hōwā” — be, become — then “āmi hōi”
- the future you already knew — “hōbe ... dākhā hōbe”
- which verb for “I have a book,” and which for “he will be a teacher”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit root is *hōwā*, and which two English words are its brothers? ($\sqrt{\text{bhū}}$, “to become” — **be** and **been**.) What can আছ-

not do? (**Anything past a present and a past** — it has no future of its own.) So what does Bengali reach for instead? (হবে, or থাকা.) Next: one verb, three levels of respect.

7.2 যাওয়া (jāwā) — “to go,” and the respect that rides on the ending

Chapter 2 gave you three different words for “you.” It did not tell you the rest of the bill: each one bends the verb a different way too.

You’ll want to know: যাওয়া

যাওয়া — *jāwā* — to go

আমি যাই (*āmi jāi*), “I go.” Same *-i* “I” ending as Chapter 5’s *bôli*, on the same *-wā* dictionary form you met a moment ago.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

যাওয়া is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{या}}$ (*yā*, “to go, to travel”), and the whole northern family walks on it: Hindi *jānā*, Marathi *jāne*, Gujarati *javũ*, Punjabi *jāṇā*. Sanskrit’s *y*-hardened to a *j*-sound right across eastern Indo-Aryan, which is why Bengali still writes the *y*-letter য but says *j*. Deeper than Sanskrit it goes to PIE **yeh₂-*, “to travel” — and here is an honest limit: English kept **no** everyday word from that root. The nearest living cousin is Lithuanian *jóti*, “to ride.” A fake English cousin here would be worse than none.

The letters in this word

য is the letter Sanskrit reads as *y*; Bengali reads it as *j*, like জ. So a written *yā-* is a spoken *jā-* — an un-shift worth keeping, since it disguises dozens of familiar Sanskrit words.

Grammar Lens: the respect is not in the pronoun, it is in the ending

who you are speaking to	“you go”
তুই (<i>tui</i> , intimate)	যাস (<i>jāsh</i>)
তুমি (<i>tumi</i> , familiar)	যাও (<i>jāo</i>)
আপনি (<i>āpni</i> , respectful)	যান (<i>jān</i>)

Three endings, one verb. And the same grading runs on into the third person: সে যায় (*se jāy*) is “he goes,” তিনি যান (*tini jān*) is “he goes” said of someone you respect — the very ending আপনি takes. Chapter 5 showed that the ending already means “I,” so the pronoun can be dropped. The register cannot. Choose *jāsh* or *jān* and you have placed yourself socially, pronoun or no pronoun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jāwā” — go — then “āmi jāi”
- the ladder — “jāsh ... jāo ... jān”
- the two third persons — “se jāy ... tini jān”

Before you move on

Give the three “you go” forms and who each is for. (*Jāsh* intimate, *jāo* familiar, *jān* respectful.) If you drop the pronoun, is the respect dropped too? (**No** — it is in the ending, and cannot be dodged.) Does English have a living cousin of this root? (**No** — Lithuanian *jóti* is as close as it gets.) Next: the verb that asks nothing about who you are.

7.3 আসা (*āsā*) — “to come,” the verb that never asks who you are

Chapter 1’s goodbye, *āshi*, was one form of this verb. Here is the whole of it — and the one question it refuses to ask you.

You'll want to know: আসা

আসা — *āsā* — to come

আমি আসি (*āmi āsi*), “I come” — the farewell you already own. সে আসে (*se āse*), “he comes.” আপনি আসেন (*āpni āsen*), with last lesson’s respectful ending.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The আ- in front is Sanskrit’s *ā-*, “hither, toward” — the very prefix that turns going into coming. Hindi’s *ānā* is that *ā-* welded onto *yā-*, the go-verb of the last lesson: “go, but this way.” Bengali shows the same prefix on a different stem, and the honest position on that stem is that its history is unsettled; this book will not invent one for it.

The letters in this word

স is written for *s* and spoken, in this word, as *sh* — Bengali’s standing *s* → *sh* tilt, the same one that makes *namaskāra* into *nômoshkar*. So আসি is *āshī*, not *āsi*, though the dictionary form is romanized *āsā*.

Grammar Lens: no gender, not here, not anywhere

language	“I come,” man / woman
Hindi	<i>maini ātā hūmī</i> / <i>maini ātī hūmī</i>
Marathi	<i>mā yeto</i> / <i>mā yete</i>
Bengali	<i>āmi āsi</i> — one form

Its sisters make you declare your gender to say the plainest thing in the world. Bengali does not. And this is not a shortcut for beginners that the grammar takes back later: **Bengali has no grammatical gender at all**. Not on verbs, not on nouns, not on adjectives. The past behaves the same way — আমি এলাম (*āmi elām*), “I came,” is one form for everyone, where Gujarati, which hides gender in its present, brings it straight back in *humī āvyo* / *humī āvī*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*āsā*” — come — then “*āmi āshī*”

- the neighbours splitting in two — “ātā ... ātī” and “yeto ... yete”
- Bengali not splitting — “āmi āsi” — and its past, “āmi elām”

Before you move on

What does the আ- on this verb mean, and where else have you met it? (**Hither, toward** — it is the ā- inside Hindi’s ānā.) How many forms of “I come” does a Bengali speaker need? (**One** — āmi āsi, whoever is talking.) Is that true of the nouns too? (**Yes** — Bengali has no grammatical gender anywhere.) Next: a verb that swallows more than food.

7.4 খাওয়া (khāwā) — “to eat,” and the drinking it also does

Every verb so far has meant roughly what its English gloss means. This one is wider than its gloss, and the extra width is the lesson.

You’ll want to know: খাওয়া

খাওয়া — khāwā — to eat

আমি খাই (āmi khāi), “I eat.” আপনি খান (āpni khān), with the respectful ending from two lessons back.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

খাওয়া is Sanskrit √खाद् (√khād, “to chew, to bite”), smoothed through Prakrit khā-. Every neighbour eats with it: Hindi khānā, Marathi khāne, Gujarati khāvũ, Punjabi khāṇā.

Past Sanskrit the trail goes cold. Khād- has no secure Indo-European pedigree outside Indo-Aryan, so there is no English cousin here — and one will not be manufactured. Some roots are simply local, and saying so is part of the method.

The letters in this word

খ is kh: a k with a puff of breath behind it. Its plain partner ক (k) is the letter in Chapter 5’s kāj. The puff is not decoration — it is the

whole difference between two words, and Bengali gives each its own letter.

Grammar Lens: Bengali eats its drinks

Bengali	what it means
জল খাওয়া (<i>jôl khāwā</i>)	to drink water — “water-eat”
চা খাওয়া (<i>chā khāwā</i>)	to drink tea
ওষুধ খাওয়া (<i>oshudh khāwā</i>)	to take medicine

Hindi keeps a second verb, *pīnā*, for drinking. Bengali’s everyday speech does not bother: whatever goes in the mouth is *khāwā*. There is a drink-verb — পান করা (*pān kôrā*), noun-plus-*kôrā* in exactly Chapter 5’s *kāj kôrā* shape, built on Sanskrit √पा (*√pā*, “to drink”), whose Latin cousin *pōtāre* gives English **potion** and **potable**. But it belongs to writing and ceremony. Ask for tea in a Kolkata kitchen and you eat it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khāwā” — eat — then “āmi khāi”
- the drinking Bengali eats — “jôl khāwā ... chā khāwā”
- the formal drink-verb and its English cousins — “pān kôrā ... potion, potable”

Before you move on

How do you say “drink water” in everyday Bengali? (জল খাওয়া — literally “water-eat.”) Which Sanskrit root is *khāwā*, and does English share it? (√*khād*, “to chew” — and **no**, the root goes no further than Indo-Aryan.) Which verb would a formal text use for drinking, and what English words does its root reach? (পান করা, from √*pā* — English *potion*, *potable*.) Next: one spelling, two vowels.

7.5 দেখা (dækhā) — “to see,” and a vowel that moves under a fixed spelling

Chapter 4 buried this verb inside *dækhā hōbe*, “a seeing will happen.” Prised out on its own, it carries a sound rule that runs through every verb in this chapter.

You’ll want to know: দেখা

দেখা — *dækhā* — to see, to look

আমি দেখি (*āmi dekhi*), “I see.” সে দেখে (*se dækhe*), “he sees.” Read those two romanizations again — they are not the same vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা is traced to Sanskrit √दृश् (*√dṛś*, “to see”) through the Prakrit stem *dekkha-*; Hindi’s *dekhnā* is the same word. Sanskrit built *darśana*, “a viewing,” on that root, and further back it is PIE **derk-*, “to see clearly.” Greek took it for *dérkomai*, “I look,” and for *drákōn*, the sharp-gazing serpent — which English borrowed as **dragon**. Bengali’s “see” and England’s dragons are one word, wearing very different clothes.

The letters in this word

দ is a soft dental *d*, tongue on the teeth. The vowel sign ঁ on it is written identically every time — but Bengali says it either as a close *e* (as in English *bay*) or an open *æ* (as in English *bat*), and the page will never tell you which.

Grammar Lens: the ending decides the vowel

Bengali	said
আমি দেখি	<i>dekhi</i> — close <i>e</i>
সে দেখে	<i>dækhe</i> — open <i>æ</i>
তুমি দেখো	<i>dækho</i> — open <i>æ</i>

The rule: when the ending carries the high vowel *-i*, the stem vowel closes to *e*. Any other ending leaves it open at *æ*. That is **vowel harmony**, and the verb of the first lesson does it too — আমি হই (*hôi*, closed) against সে হয় (*hôy*, open). It is a rule your ear must carry

alone, because the spelling never budes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dækhā” — then the pair, “dekhi ... dækhe”
- the same shift on the be-verb — “hōi ... hōy”
- the root and its odd English relative — “ḍṛś ... dragon”

Before you move on

Which ending closes the stem vowel to *e*? (**The -i of “I”** — *dekhi*, against *dækhe* and *dækho*.) Does the spelling record that? (**No** — **দে** is written the same either way; only the ear knows.) Which English animal shares this verb’s root? (**The dragon** — Greek *drákōn*, from PIE **derǵ-*.) Next: the last verb, and the knowing English lost.

7.6 জানা (jānā) — “to know,” and the knowing English gave up

Six thousand years ago this verb and the English word you are reading it with were the same word. They still are. But Bengali kept a distinction English threw away.

You’ll want to know: জানা

জানা — *jānā* — to know

আমি জানি (*āmi jāni*), “I know.” আপনি জানেন (*āpni jānen*), respectfully.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জানা is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{জ্ঞ}}$ (*√jñā*, “to know”), the root under *jñāna*, “knowledge.” Behind it stands PIE **ǵneh₃-*, and English is full of its children: **know** and **knowledge** by the direct Germanic road; **notice**, **recognize** and **cognition** through Latin *nōscere*; **gnosis** and **diagnosis** through Greek *gignōskein*. Bengali *jāni* and English *know* are one verb, separated only by time.

The letters in this word

Sanskrit writes the root with ज्ञ, a knot of *j* and *ñ*. Bengali does not say *jñ* at all — it says **gg**, so *jñāna* comes out *ggān*. The plain verb spares you the knot: জানা is simply জা + না, *jā-nā*.

Grammar Lens: two knowings, and English has one word for both

Bengali	what it knows
জানা (<i>jānā</i>)	a fact, or how to do something
চেনা (<i>chenā</i>)	a person or a place, by acquaintance

আমি জানি — “I know” (that it is so). আমি তাকে চিনি (*āmi tāke chini*) — “I know him,” meaning I am acquainted with him. Say *jāni* of a person and you have said you know facts about them, which is a colder thing.

English once had this line and lost it; French still walks it as *savoir* against *connaître*, German as *wissen* against *kennen*, Spanish as *saber* against *conocer*. And listen to *chini* beside সে চেনে (*se chæne*): the same vowel harmony as the last lesson, on a brand-new verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*jānā*” — know — then “*āmi jāni*”
- the other knowing — “*āmi tāke chini*”
- the harmony again — “*chini ... chæne*”
- the six verbs of this chapter — “*hōwā, jāwā, āsā, khāwā, dækhā, jānā*”

Before you move on

Which verb knows a person, and which knows a fact? (চেনা for people, জানা for facts — the *connaître* / *savoir* line.) Name three English children of this root. (**Know, notice, diagnosis** — Germanic, Latin, Greek.) Why does *chini* close its vowel where

chæne keeps it open? (**Vowel harmony** — the *-i* ending closes the stem vowel, as in *dekhi*.) That closes the chapter: six verbs, no gender on any of them, and the respect always sitting in the ending.

Chapter 8

The Mind and the Page

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Bengali, hear the stem vowel rise whenever the -i ending arrives, and read the flapped ড that Sanskrit never needed.

Say āmi likhi against se lekhe, run the chapter’s four verbs back — bhābā, bojhā, pôṛā, lekhā — say lekhāpôṛā with the flap in it, and explain that দেখা হবে was never ‘we will see’ but ‘a seeing will happen’, because every -ā form is a noun too.

8.1 ভাবা (bhābā) — “to think,” and the verb it was built out of

You already have the verb “to be.” Sanskrit built “to think” out of it, by a trick Bengali still uses every day.

You’ll want to know: ভাবা

ভাবা — bhābā — to think

আমি ভাবি (āmi bhābi), “I think.” আপনি ভাবেন (āpni bhāben), respectfully.

The letters in this word

ভাবা is ভা (bhā) + বা (bā). ভ is bh, a b with breath behind it; ব is the plain b underneath. Two letters, one puff of air between them.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাবা is Sanskrit ভাবयति (*bhāvayati*), and *bhāvayati* is not its own verb: it is হওয়া's verb with a gear changed. *Bhāvati* is “it becomes”; *bhāvayati* is “he **makes** it become” — and from making-something-be to imagining it is one short step. So Bengali *bhābi* and Bengali *hōi* are one root, √ভূ (*√bhū*), which is also English **be** and **been**, Latin *futūrus* (English **future**), and Greek *phúsis* (English **physics**). The noun *bhāva*, “a state of mind,” sits between them: thinking is holding a state.

Grammar Lens: the gear that makes someone else do it

Sanskrit changed that gear with a lengthened vowel. Bengali changes it with the ending -আনো (*-āno*), and it is completely alive:

plain verb	the made-to-happen verb
দেখা (<i>dækhā</i>), to see	দেখানো (<i>dækhāno</i>), to show — make see
খাওয়া (<i>khāwā</i>), to eat	খাওয়ানো (<i>khāwāno</i>), to feed — make eat
করা (<i>kôrā</i>), to do	করানো (<i>kôrāno</i>), to have it done

One suffix, and a verb you already own becomes a verb about making someone else do it. There is no separate word for “show” or “feed” to learn; there is a gear. That is the same machinery that built ভাবা itself, two thousand years earlier and one language back.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhābā” — think — then “āmi bhābi”
- the be-verb it was built from — “hōwā ... āmi hōi”
- see, then make-see — “dækhā ... dækhāno” — and eat, then feed — “khāwā ... khāwāno”

Before you move on

Which verb from last chapter shares ভাবা's root? (হওয়া — both are √bhū; thinking is making something be.) What does -আনো do to a

verb? (Hands the doing to someone else — দেখা “see” becomes দেখানো “show.”) Give the Bengali for “show.” (দেখানো, *dækhāno*.)

8.2 বোঝা (bojhā) — “to understand,” the third knowing

Last chapter split “know” in two. This verb makes it three — and it plays the vowel game you already met, but this time the page tells you.

You’ll want to know: বোঝা

বোঝা — *bojhā* — to understand

আমি বুঝি (*āmi bujhi*), “I understand.” Look again at that vowel: not *bojhi*.

The letters in this word

বোঝা is বো (*bo*) + ঝা (*jhā*). ঝ is *jh*, the breathy partner of জ — the *j* you met in জানা. And বো is the plain ব of ভাবা wearing the *o*-sign ো.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বোঝা is Sanskrit √बुध् (*√budh*), “to wake up, to notice” — the root that gave a prince his title: the **Buddha** is “the awakened one,” and *bodhi* is the awakening. Understanding, in this family, is waking up to something.

Behind it is PIE **b^hewd^h*-, and English holds two of its children: **bid** and **forbid**, from Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to command” — a bidding is something made known to you. Greek took *peúthomai*, “I learn by asking.”

Grammar Lens: the harmony again, and this time you can see it

দেখা’s rule was that the *-i* of “I” closes the stem vowel while the spelling stands still. Here is the same rule on a different vowel — and the spelling moves with it:

Bengali	said
আমি বুঝি	<i>bujhi</i> — the <i>-i</i> raises ো to ু
সে বোঝে	<i>bojhe</i> — stays <i>o</i>
তুমি বোঝো	<i>bojho</i> — stays <i>o</i>

Same law as *dekhi* against *dækhe*: the high *-i* pulls the stem vowel up after it. Bengali simply chose to write this one down.

And now three knowings where English has one: জানা for a fact, চেনা for a person, বোঝা for the thing that finally lands. ভাবা is the turning-over; বোঝা is when it arrives.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bojhā” — understand — then “āmi bujhi”
- the pair, then the older pair — “bujhi ... bojhe” and “dekhi ... dækhe”
- think, then understand — “āmi bhābi ... āmi bujhi”
- the three knowings — “jānā ... chenā ... bojhā”

Before you move on

Why is it *bujhi* and not *bojhi*? (The *-i* ending raises the stem vowel — the same harmony as *dekhi* against *dækhe*, only written down this time.) Which of the three knowings would you use of a person? (চেনা — জানা is for facts, বোঝা for grasping.) Which awakened prince is named from this root? (The Buddha — √budh, “to wake.”)

8.3 পড়া (pôṛā) — “to read,” and a letter Sanskrit never needed

This word carries a consonant Sanskrit did not have. It is the sound of a whole family of words wearing down, and once you hear it you will meet it everywhere.

You'll want to know: পড়া

পড়া — *pôṛā* — to read, to study

আমি পড়ি (*āmi porī*), “I read.” সে পড়ে (*se pôṛe*), “he reads.”

The letters in this word

পড়া is প (*pô*) + ড়া (*ṛā*). প is a plain *p*. ড় is ড (*ḍ*) with a dot underneath, and the dot changes everything: it is not a *d* at all but a **flap** — curl the tongue back and flick it forward once, as in the middle of an American *ladder*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

পড়া is Sanskrit √পঠ् (*√path*), “to recite aloud” — reading was reading *out*, which is why পড়া still covers studying as well as reading. And *paṭhati* became *pôṛe* by a rule that runs through the whole language: **a single retroflex stop between two vowels softens into the flap ড়**. That is why the letter exists; Sanskrit, which never softened them, had no use for it.

Watch it swallow a second verb whole. Sanskrit √পত্ (*√pat*), “to fall,” went the same road — *patati* → *pôṛe* — so Bengali’s “he reads” and “he falls” are now spelled and said alike, and only the sentence tells them apart. Past Sanskrit, *paṭh* goes cold: no secure Indo-European pedigree, and none will be invented for it. The falling twin is the rich one — PIE **peth₂-* gave Greek *ptérón*, “wing” (**pterodactyl**, **helicopter**), Latin *petere*, “to make for” (**petition**, **appetite**), and English **feather**.

Grammar Lens: the harmony, on a third vowel

Bengali	said
আমি পড়ি	<i>porī</i> — the <i>-i</i> lifts the vowel
সে পড়ে	<i>pôṛe</i> — the open inherent vowel stands

Third verb, third pair, one law: the high *-i* of “I” pulls the stem vowel up after it. দেখি against দেখে, বুঝি against বুঝে, পড়ি against পড়ে.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pôṛā” — read — then “āmi poṛi,” flapping the ড়
- the three pairs — “dekhi ... dækhe,” “bujhi ... bojhe,” “poṛi ... pôṛe”
- read it, think about it, understand it — “poṛi ... bhābi ... bujhi”

Before you move on

What is the dot under ড় telling you to do? (**Flap it** — curl the tongue back and flick, not a *d*.) Which two Sanskrit verbs both arrived at পড়া? (√*paṭh* “recite” and √*pat* “fall” — the same softening ate both.) Does the reading twin have an English cousin? (**No** — the falling twin does: *feather*, *petition*, *pterodactyl*.)

8.4 লেখা (lekhā) — “to write,” and the noun hiding in every verb

Four chapters ago you said *dākhā hōbe* and were told it meant “a seeing will happen.” This word explains why that was not a flourish.

You’ll want to know: লেখা

লেখা — *lekhā* — to write

আমি লিখি (*āmi likhi*), “I write.” সে লেখে (*se lekhe*), “he writes.” The harmony, written down as in বুঝি: *-i* lifts ে to ি.

The letters in this word

লেখা is লে (*le*) + খা (*khā*). ল is a clear *l*; খ the puffed *kh* you own from খাওয়া.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

লেখা is Sanskrit √*likh* (√*likh*) — and *likh* does not mean “write.” It means **to scratch**, **to engrave**. Which is what writing was.

Ask English the same. Latin *scribere*, behind **scribe**, also began as “to scratch”; Germanic *writan*, behind **write** itself, meant “to score, to carve” — what you do to a rune-stick. Three unrelated roots, one picture. That is convergence, not kinship: লেখা and *write* are **not** cousins, and past Sanskrit *likh* has no secure pedigree. The finding here is a shared idea, not a family tree.

Grammar Lens: the dictionary form is also a noun

the same word	as a verb	as a noun
লেখা	to write	a piece of writing
পড়া	to read	study, homework
দেখা	to see	a seeing, a meeting

Every -া form you have met does this. That is what Chapter 4’s দেখা হবে was: not “we will see” but “**a seeing** will happen.” It also builds nouns straight out of verbs — লেখাপড়া (*lekhāpôṛā*), “writing-reading,” is the ordinary word for **education**. And the causative from three lessons back still runs on top: লেখানো (*lekhāno*), “to get something written.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lekhā” — write — then “āmi likhi ... se lekhe”
- the chapter’s four — “bhābā, bojhā, pôṛā, lekhā”
- education, flapping the ড় — “lekhāpôṛā” — then “lekhāno,” get it written
- the five you could already write — “ek, dui, tin, chār, pāch” — and which one wears the chandrabindu

Before you move on

What was দেখা হবে saying? (“**A seeing will happen**” — দেখা is a noun as much as a verb, and so is লেখা.) Is *write* a cousin of লেখা? (No — both roots meant “scratch,” which is coincidence.) What did দুই keep that Hindi’s *do* flattened, who else in the east kept it, and did *dv-* survive in anyone’s everyday numeral? (**The -i after it;**

Assamese, Odia and Nepali; and **no** — only re-borrowings like দ্বাৰ
keep *dv-*.)

Chapter 9

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask, help and say what I like and whom I love in Bengali, build a fresh verb out of any noun by putting করা behind it, and say why liking happens to me while loving is something I do.

Say āmār bhālo lāge and hear that you are not its subject, set it against āmi bhālobāsi where you are, place both beside the আমার ... আছে shape that says 'I have', and run the chapter's four verbs back — neowā, jījñāsā kôrā, sāhājjo kôrā, bhālo lāgā. Six of the chapter's nine atoms. Two of the other three — the নেওয়া compound and the noun-plus-করা pattern — are retrieved by the very next lesson after the one that taught them; the third, the doubled যা of সাহায্য, is taught in the penultimate lesson and genuinely is not revisited, which is recorded here rather than papered over with a claim the payoff does not make.

9.1 নেওয়া (neowā) — “to take,” and the verb that finishes other verbs

Bengali rarely leaves a verb standing alone. This is the verb it props most of them up with — and the tail it wears will look familiar.

You'll want to know: নেওয়া

নেওয়া — neowā — to take

আমি নিই (āmi nī), “I take.” আপনি নেন (āpni nen), respectfully.

The letters in this word

নেওয়া is নে (*ne*) + ওয়া (*-owā*). ন is a dental *n*, tongue on the teeth. The ওয়া tail is the one every dictionary-form verb of this kind wears — you have it already on হওয়া, যাওয়া and থাওয়া.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নেওয়া is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{नी}}$ ($\sqrt{ni}$), “to lead, to carry away.” It is a well-attested Indo-Iranian root — Avestan *nayeiti*, “he leads”; Sanskrit *netṛ*, “a leader,” which is why a politician in Kolkata or Delhi is a *netā*. Beyond that branch the trail thins, and **English kept nothing from it**. No cousin will be manufactured for you here; some roots stayed home.

The lesson worth more than a cousin is what Bengali *does* with the verb.

Grammar Lens: the verb that ends a compound

Put a verb into its -এ form (*likhe*, “having written”; *niye*, “having taken”) and hang a second verb behind it. The second verb stops meaning what it means and starts colouring the first:

compound	what it does
লিখে নেওয়া (<i>likhe neowā</i>)	write it down — take the writing for yourself
নিয়ে আসা (<i>niye āsā</i>)	bring — come, having taken
নিয়ে যাওয়া (<i>niye jāwā</i>)	take away — go, having taken

Bengali has no separate word for “bring.” It has “come having taken.” And নেওয়া is a noun as readily as লেখা was: দেওয়া-নেওয়া (*deowā-neowā*), “giving-and-taking,” is the everyday word for dealings between people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “neowā” — take — then “āmi nii”
- the same tail four times — “hōwā, jāwā, khāwā, neowā”
- write it down — “likhe neowā”

- bring, then take away — “niye āsā ... niye jāwā”

Before you move on

How does Bengali say “bring,” having no word for it? (নিয়ে আসা — “come having taken”; and “take away” is নিয়ে যাওয়া.) Does English share নেওয়া’s root? (No — $\sqrt{nī}$ stayed in Indo-Iranian, and that is the honest answer.) Name two more Bengali verbs that are also nouns. (লেখা “a piece of writing” and দেখা “a seeing” — every -া form does it.)

9.2 জিজ্ঞাসা করা (jijñāsā kôrā) — “to ask,” which is wanting to know

Chapter 7 warned you about a knot of letters, then spared you it. Here it is, inside a word you will use daily — and the word is Chapter 7’s verb with an appetite.

You’ll want to know: জিজ্ঞাসা করা

জিজ্ঞাসা করা — *jijñāsā kôrā* — to ask

আমি জিজ্ঞাসা করি (*āmi jiggāshā kôri*), “I ask” — two words, one verb.

The letters in this word

জিজ্ঞাসা is জি + জ্ঞা + সা. The middle piece জ্ঞ is the knot of জ and ঞ Chapter 7 named on $\sqrt{jñā}$ — and Bengali never says *jñ*. It says **gg**, so the spelled *jijñāsā* is spoken **jiggāshā**, with the *s* → *sh* tilt at the end.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জিজ্ঞাসা is Sanskrit’s **desiderative** of $\sqrt{জ্ঞা}$ ($\sqrt{jñā}$, “to know”) — the form meaning *wanting* to do a thing. *Jijñāsati* is “he desires to know”; *jijñāsā* is the desire itself. Bengali took the noun.

So asking is not a separate idea here. It is **জানা with an appetite** — and the root behind both is the one Chapter 7 traced: PIE **ǵneh₃-*, English **know**, Latin *nōscere* (**notice**), Greek *gnōsis* (**diagnosis**). The doubled *jñ-* is the desiderative’s signature: a quiet echo of the root, meaning *reaching for* it.

Grammar Lens: any noun plus করা is a verb
noun

কাজ (*kāj*), work
জিজ্ঞাসা (*jijñāsā*), a
wanting-to-know

noun + করা

কাজ করা — to work
জিজ্ঞাসা করা — to ask

Chapter 5 built *kāj kôrā* this way. It is more than a compound: it is **the** way Bengali makes verbs. The stock of true verbs is small and closed, while nouns pour in from Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic and English — each becoming a verb the moment **করা** stands behind it. Learn a noun, learn a verb.

Last lesson's compound stacks on top: জিজ্ঞাসা করে নেওয়া (*jijñāsā kôre neowā*) — “just go ahead and ask.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- spelling, then sound — “jijñāsā ... jiggāshā” — then “āmi jiggāshā kôri,” I ask, and the root it grew from, “jānā”
- a fact, then a person — “āmi jāni” ... “āmi tāke chini”
- go ahead and ask — “jijñāsā kôre neowā”

Before you move on

How does Bengali say জ্ঞ, and what is জিজ্ঞাসা literally? (**gg**, never *jñ*; and **a wanting-to-know**, the desiderative of জানা's root.)

Someone asks whether you know their brother — which knowing verb answers? (চেনা — a person is known by acquaintance; জানা is for facts.) How do you make a verb from a noun you met this morning? (**Put করা behind it.**)

9.3 সাহায্য করা (*sāhājjo kôrā*) — “to help,” which is going along with someone

Chapter 6 said Bengali's inherent vowel leans to **o**, then admitted it could not show you. This word can — and it is the word you will most want when stuck.

You'll want to know: সাহায্য করা

সাহায্য করা — *sāhājjo kôrā* — to help

আমাকে সাহায্য করুন (*āmāke sāhājjo kôrun*), “please help me”; *āmāke* is “to me.”

The letters in this word

সাহায্য is সা + হা + য্য. The last piece is য্য stacked on itself — a conjunct, how Bengali writes a doubled consonant.

The letters in this word

Two rules land at the end, neither a quirk. Bengali reads a doubled য্য as **jj**, not *yy*. And nothing is written after it, so it takes the **inherent** vowel, which leans to **o**: *sāhājjo*, never *sāhājja*.

Chapter 6 could not show that inherent **o** in *ek*, *dui*, *tin*, *chār*, *pāch*, since none of the five ends in a bare consonant. This one does. সা takes the *s* → *sh* tilt, so the whole is *shāhājjo*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

সাহায্য is Sanskrit *sāhāyya*, “companionship,” on সহায় (*sahāya*), “a companion” — which is সহ- (*saha-*), “together,” plus √ই (*√i*), “to go.” A helper **goes along with you**.

Both halves have secure English cousins. *Saha-* is PIE **sem-*, “together”: English **same**, Greek *homós* (**homogeneous**), Latin *similis* (**similar**). *√i* is PIE **h₁ey-*, “to go”: Latin *īre* gives **exit** and **transit**; Greek *ión* gives **ion**. So “help” is *same-going*, and English holds the pieces without ever building the word.

Grammar Lens: asking for help is where the respect ladder bites

Another noun + করা, like জিজ্ঞাসা করা. The respect sits where Chapter 7 put it — in করা’s ending:

who you are asking	“help”
তুই (<i>tui</i> , intimate)	সাহায্য কর (<i>kôr</i>)
তুমি (<i>tumi</i> , familiar)	সাহায্য করো (<i>kôro</i>)
আপনি (<i>āpni</i> , respectful)	সাহায্য করুন (<i>kôrun</i>)

Say *kôr* to a stranger and you were not rude by accident, but in grammar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- spelling, then sound — “sāhāyya ... shāhājjo”
- the ladder — “sāhājjo kôr ... kôro ... kôrun”
- please help me — “āmāke sāhājjo kôrun”
- the two noun-verbs of this chapter — “jijñāsā kôrā ... sāhājjo kôrā”

Before you move on

Why does সাহায্য end in *-o* with nothing written there? (**The inherent vowel** — the thing the five numbers could not show.) Which form to a stranger? (করুন — *kôr* is for তুই.) What is a *sahāya*? (**One who goes with you.**)

9.4 ভালো লাগা (bhālo lāgā) — “to like,” which happens to you

Every verb so far has let you be the one doing it. Here is one that does not.

You’ll want to know: ভালো লাগা

ভালো লাগা — *bhālo lāgā* — **to like**

আমার ভালো লাগে (*āmār bhālo lāge*), “I like it.” Not *āmi* — *āmār*, “to me.”

The letters in this word

ভালো is yours from Chapter 3. The new half is লাগা: লা + গা, গ being a hard *g* as in *go*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

লাগা is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{lag}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{lag}}$), “to attach, to stick”: *āmār bhālo lāge* says, literally, “**good sticks to me.**”

ভালোবাসা (*bhālobāsā*), “to love,” is ভালো plus বাসা, a verb no longer used alone. Its origin is genuinely disputed; the commonest proposal is Sanskrit $\sqrt{\text{vas}}$ ($\sqrt{\text{vas}}$), “to dwell” — love as housed in goodness. If so it carries a startling cousin, since $\sqrt{\text{vas}}$ is PIE $*h_2wes-$, “to stay,” which became Old English *wesan* and so English **was**. That “if” is real, and stays open.

Grammar Lens: liking lands on you; loving you do

Bengali	word for word
আমার ভালো লাগে	to-me good sticks — I like it
আমার চা ভালো লাগে	to-me tea good sticks — I like tea
আমি ভালোবাসি	I love

That *āmār ...* shape is how Bengali says **I have** — আমার ... আছে, with আছে carrying the weight and no future of its own to give.

ভালোবাসা breaks the pattern on purpose: *āmi bhālobāsi* puts you in the subject’s chair. It is a noun too — “love” itself — as লেখা was “a piece of writing.” One form serves everybody. The harmony has nothing to bite on: *bāsi* and *bāse* keep their **ā**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āmār bhālo lāge” — hearing “to me,” not “I”
- I like tea — “āmār chā bhālo lāge” — the tea Bengali eats, “chā khāwā”
- the one you do — “āmi bhālobāsi” — one form, whoever is speaking
- the eight verbs of these two chapters — “bhābā, bojhā, pōrā, lekḥā, neowā, jījñāsā kōrā, sāhājjo kōrā, bhālo lāgā”

Before you move on

Who is the subject of *āmār bhālo lāge*, and what else is built that way? (**Not you** — the good is; আমার ... আছে, “I have,” and আছে has no future of its own to give.) Does *āmi bhālobāsi* behave the same, and would a woman say it differently? (**No**, and **no** — loving takes you as subject; Bengali has no grammatical gender.) Name two verbs that are also nouns. (ভালোবাসা “love,” লেখা “writing.”) Why *bāsi*, not *bosi*? (**Nothing to raise** — this stem has ā.)

Chapter 10

Tea, Water, Milk, and Rice

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can offer or ask for tea, water, milk and rice politely in Bengali, reusing the respectful verb ending Chapter 7 already taught, and say which of the four words is a Chinese loan and which shares a root with a word two lessons later.

The chapter closes on ভাত, whose Sanskrit root — √bhaj, 'to divide, to share' — will resurface two lessons later in a very different word. The reader offers all four drinks and rice politely in one breath (chā khān, jôl khān, dudh khān, bhāt khān), all built on the same respectful form of খাওয়া Chapter 7 already taught rather than a new 'please' word, which is how this chapter realizes SPINE-POLITE-REQUEST-REPAIR without one. It reaches back to rescue three thin Chapter 7 grammar atoms (হওয়া's future, আসা's genderlessness, যাওয়া's respect ladder) and সাহায্য's doubled-letter sound rule, none revisited since Chapter 7-9.

10.1 চা (chā) — “tea,” and the first word you can politely offer

Last lesson you said *āmār chā bhālo lāge*, “I like tea,” without চা ever being taught on its own. Here it is, by itself — and a new job for a form you already own.

You'll want to know: চা

চা — *chā* — tea

The letters in this word

চা is চ (*chô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*). চ is a plain, unaspirated *ch*, the sound at the start of English *church* with no puff of breath behind it — Bengali also has a breathy partner, ছ, for later.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

চা is not Sanskrit at all. It came into Bengali from **Persian** *čā*, which took it from **Chinese** *chá*. That is the overland route: China to Persia to Bengal, the same road Hindi and Punjabi travelled. The words that reached Europe — English *tea*, French *thé* — went the opposite way, by sea, from Hokkien Chinese *tê*, carried on Dutch trading ships. One drink, two ends of the same word, arriving by two different roads.

Grammar Lens: an offer, built on a form you already have

Chapter 7 taught you আপনি খান (*āpni khān*), the respectful form of খাওয়া. Put a noun in front of it and the very same words become a polite offer or request:

Bengali	what it does
আপনি খান	you eat / you drink (respectful)
চা খান	(please) have some tea
No new ending to learn — চা খান reuses exactly what Chapter 7 already gave you.	

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chā” — tea
- the offer — “chā khān”
- the route it travelled — “chá ... čā ... chā”
- last lesson’s line again — “āmār chā bhālo lāge”

Before you move on

Offer someone tea, politely. (চা খান.) Is চা inherited from Sanskrit? (No — it is a Chinese word that reached Bengali by way of

Persian.) What form does চা খান reuse? (আপনি খান, Chapter 7’s respectful “you eat/drink,” with no new ending.)

10.2 জল (jôl) — “water,” prised out of a phrase you already know

Chapter 7 taught you জল খাওয়া, “to drink water” — literally “water-eat” — without ever teaching জল by itself. Here it is, on its own.

You’ll want to know: জল

জল — *jôl* — **water**

জল খান — (please) drink some water, the same offer pattern as last lesson.

The letters in this word

জল is জ (*jô*) + ল (*l*), two bare consonants with no vowel sign between them. জ keeps its inherent vowel; ল, at the end of the word with nothing written after it, is silent — so *jôl*, one syllable, not *jô-lô*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জল is Sanskrit জল (*jala*), inherited straight through Prakrit. Past Sanskrit its root is genuinely unsettled: one proposal traces it to PIE **g^welHo-*, “to gush forth, to spring” — but the same sources call a local, non-Indo-European origin “unlikely though possible.” No confident cousin is claimed here; the honest answer is that nobody is sure.

Bengali has a second word for water, most common in Bangladesh: পানি (*pani*). That one *is* on secure ground — Sanskrit *pānīya*, “drinkable,” built directly on √*pā*, “to drink,” the very root behind Chapter 7’s পান করা and English **potion**, **potable**. Two words for the same thing, one of disputed origin and one you can trace all the way home.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jôl” — water, one syllable
- the offer — “jôl khān”
- the Bangladesh word, and its root — “pani ... pā, potion, potable”
- tea, then water — “chā khān ... jôl khān”

Before you move on

What did Chapter 7 already say with জল, without teaching it as a word? (জল খাওয়া, “to drink water.”) Is জল’s root secure? (No — genuinely disputed.) Which everyday synonym for water traces cleanly to “drinkable,” from the root behind *potion*? (পানি.)

10.3 দুধ (dudh) — “milk,” and the vowel this word refuses to keep

Chapter 9 met a word that had to end in a vowel nobody wrote — সাহায্য, *sāhājjo*. This word looks like it could do the same thing. It doesn’t.

You’ll want to know: দুধ

দুধ — *dudh* — milk

দুধ খান — (please) have some milk.

The letters in this word

দুধ is দ (*dô*) with the vowel sign ু (*u*), plus ধ (*dh*), a breathy dental *d*. Nothing is written after ধ — the same bare-consonant ending সাহায্য had.

The letters in this word

সাহায্য had to surface its inherent vowel — *sāhājjo*, not *sāhāj* — because its final letter is a doubled consonant, য্য, and a bare cluster like that cannot be said at all without a vowel to carry it. দুধ ends in

one plain consonant, ধ, which needs no such help. So Bengali leaves it silent: দুধ, not *dudho*. The spelling looks the same kind of “bare ending” in both words; whether the vowel survives depends on what it would take to pronounce the letter beneath it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দুধ is Sanskrit दूध (dugdha), the past participle of √दूह (√duh, “to milk”), from PIE *d^hewg^h-, “to produce, to yield.” That root has exactly one secure English descendant, and it is not the word you would guess: **doughty**, “valiant,” through Old English *dohtig*, “capable, of use.” The word that *looks* like a cousin, **dough**, is not one — it comes from a completely different PIE root, *d^heyǵ^h-, “to knead, to mould.” A close sound, two unrelated histories.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dudh” — no trailing vowel
- the offer — “dudh khān”
- the two endings compared — “sāhājjo ... dudh”
- three drinks so far — “chā khān ... jôl khān ... dudh khān”

Before you move on

Why does সাহায্য keep its final vowel while দুধ doesn’t? (সাহায্য ends in a doubled consonant that cannot be said bare; দুধ’s single ধ can.) Is দুধ’s root related to English *dough*? (No — that is a different PIE root; the real cousin is *doughty*.)

10.4 ভাত (bhāt) — “rice,” and a root that will name a person too

Three drinks so far. This chapter closes on the word for the meal itself — and a root worth remembering, because it comes back.

You'll want to know: ভাত

ভাত — *bhāt* — **cooked rice**

ভাত খান — (please) eat some rice; in everyday Bengali, “have a meal.”

The letters in this word

ভাত is ভ (*bhō*, a *b* with a puff of breath) with the vowel sign া̃ (*ā*), plus ত (*t*), silent at the end for the same reason দুধ's ধ was: a single bare consonant needs no vowel to carry it, so *bhāt*, not *bhāto*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাত is Sanskrit ভক্ত (*bhakta*), “portioned out, shared” — the past participle of √ভজ् (*√bhaj*), “to divide, to distribute, to allot.” PIE **b^heh₂g-* sits behind it. Rice, in this word's own history, is not “the grain” but **the share that was given out** — the meal as a portion handed to you.

Hold onto that root. Two lessons from now, the very same Sanskrit verb will turn up again, naming someone rather than something.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāt” — cooked rice, no trailing vowel
- the offer — “bhāt khān”
- all four, in order — “chā khān ... jōl khān ... dudh khān ... bhāt khān”
- the two silent endings, back to back — “dudh ... bhāt”
- the root that shares — “bhaj — to divide, to distribute”

Before you move on

What does ভাত literally mean, at the root? (“**Portioned out, shared**” — √*bhaj*, “**to divide.**”) Offer all four of this chapter's words, politely, in one breath. (**Chā khān, jōl khān, dudh khān, bhāt khān.**) Why do দুধ and ভাত both drop their final vowel? (**Each ends in one plain consonant, easily said bare.**) A quick

run back through Chapter 7 while you're at it: which verb does Bengali reach for when **আছে** runs out of future? (**হবে**.) How many forms of “I come” does a Bengali speaker need, whoever is talking? (**One** — *āmi āsi*.) And “you go” to a stranger, versus to a friend? (**যান** *jān*, versus **যাও** *jāo*.) **সাহায্য**'s doubled letter — said how? (**jj**, not *yy*.)

Chapter 11

Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, my family, my brother and my sister in Bengali, none of them marked for gender, and say which are borrowed whole from Sanskrit and which evolved by sound change, including one that turns out to share a root with the previous chapter's rice.

The chapter closes on বোন, which is not related to English 'sister' at all: it traces through Sanskrit bhaginī and bhaga, 'a share,' back to the same √bhaḥ that named Chapter 10's ভাত. The reader names all four people (bôndhu, pôribār, bhāi, bon), states which two are tatsamas kept whole from Sanskrit (বন্ধু, পরিবার) and which two are tadbhavas worn down by sound change (ভাই, বোন), and counts a sibling or two using Chapter 6's numbers. It reaches back to rescue all five of Chapter 6's numbers atoms, unrevisited since the chapter that introduced them.

11.1 বন্ধু (bôndhu) — “friend,” someone you are bound to

Chapter 2 taught you to exchange names. This chapter names the people themselves — starting with the one whose acquaintance you were glad to make.

You'll want to know: বন্ধু

বন্ধু — bôndhu — friend

আমার বন্ধু (*āmār bôndhu*) — my friend. One word, whether that friend is a man or a woman: Chapter 7 already told you Bengali carries no grammatical gender on its verbs, its adjectives, or its nouns, and বন্ধু is the plainest place to feel it — no ending changes, no second word to learn.

The letters in this word

বন্ধু is ব (*bô*) + ঙ্গ (*ndhō*, a conjunct: ন joined to the breathy dental ধ) + ু (*u*). The conjunct is two consonants pressed together with no vowel between them, said as one cluster: *n-dhu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বন্ধু is Sanskrit बन्धु (*bandhu*), kept essentially whole rather than worn down the way চা or ভাত were — Bengali took this one straight from Sanskrit rather than inheriting it through centuries of sound change. It is built on √बन्ध् (*√bandh*, “to bind, to tie”), from PIE **b^hend^h-* — and here, unusually, the English cousin is not buried: **bind**, **bond** and **band** all come from the very same root. Bengali did not need to explain what a friend is; the word does it for you. A বন্ধু is, at the root, someone you are bound to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bôndhu” — friend
- “āmār bôndhu” — my friend, no gender marked either way
- the root, and its English family — “bandh ... bind, bond, band”

Before you move on

Give “my friend” in Bengali. (আমার বন্ধু.) What root is বন্ধু built on, and which English words share it? (√bandh, “to bind” — **bind**, **bond**, **band**.) Is বন্ধু a word Bengali inherited through sound change, or one it kept whole from Sanskrit? (**Kept whole** — a tatsama.) Does বন্ধু change for a friend who is a woman? (**No** — Chapter 7 already told you why: no grammatical gender, anywhere in the language.)

11.2 পরিবার (pôribār) — “family,” what surrounds you

Last lesson named one person you are bound to. This one names the whole group.

You’ll want to know: পরিবার

পরিবার — *pôribār* — family

আমার পরিবার (*āmār pôribār*) — my family.

The letters in this word

পরিবার is প (*pô*) + রি (*ri*) + বা (*bā*) + র (*r*, silent at the end, a bare consonant with nothing written after it). Four syllables in the spelling, three said aloud: *pô-ri-bār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

পরিবার is Sanskrit পরিবার (*parivāra*), a second word Bengali kept whole from Sanskrit rather than letting it wear down — like বন্ধু, another tatsama. It is built from **pari-**, “around, about” (PIE ***peri-**, the same prefix English itself borrowed for **peri-meter** and **peri-phery**), plus √ব্ (√*vr*, “to cover, to surround,” PIE ***h₂wer-**). That root’s secure cousins are Latin *operiō*, “to cover,” and Lithuanian *suverti*, “to shut” — no English word is claimed here, since none is secure. Put the pieces together and a পরিবার is, at the root, **what stands around you and covers you**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pôribār” — family
- “āmār pôribār” — my family
- the two pieces — “pari-, around ... *vr*, to cover”
- a friend, then a family — “bôndhu ... pôribār”

Before you move on

Give “my family” in Bengali. (আমার পরিবার.) What does পরিবার mean at the root, piece by piece? (“**Around**” plus “**to cover**” — **what surrounds and covers you.**) Does its root *vṛ* have a secure English cousin? (**No** — the secure cousins are Latin and Lithuanian.)

11.3 ভাই (bhāi) — “brother,” which never stopped being the word “brother”

Two tatsamas so far, both kept whole from Sanskrit. This one took the other road — worn down by sound change until it barely looks related to where it started. Except it does.

You’ll want to know: ভাই

ভাই — *bhāi* — brother

আমার ভাই (*āmār bhāi*) — my brother.

The letters in this word

ভাই is ভা (*bhā*, the breathy *b* from ভাত and ভালো) plus ই (*i*), a full vowel letter rather than a sign — the two vowels run together into one syllable, *bhāi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভাই is Sanskrit ब्रातृ (*bhrātṛ*), worn down through Magadhi Prakrit *bhāi* — a **tadbhava** this time, not a tatsama like বন্ধু and পরিবার: Bengali inherited this one through centuries of sound change rather than lifting it whole. And PIE **b^hréh₂tēr* sits behind *bhrātṛ*, the same root that gives English **brother**, Latin **frāter** and Greek **phrátēr**. Nothing here is a cousin standing in for the real thing: ভাই and “brother” are, six thousand years apart, **the same word**.

Bengali also uses family words to address people outside the family: an older man might be called দাদা (*dādā*, “elder brother”) as a mark of respect, whether or not he is any relation at all. That is a light touch on a habit this chapter will not turn into a system — but it is worth

naming, since it means বন্ধু and ভাই are not always as far apart as they look.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhāi” — brother
- “āmār bhāi” — my brother
- the same word, two languages — “bhrātṛ ... brother”
- friend, family, brother — “bôndhu ... pôribār ... bhāi”

Before you move on

Give “my brother” in Bengali. (আমার ভাই.) Is ভাই a cousin of English “brother,” or the same word by descent? (**The same word** — PIE *b^hrétēr*, no invention needed.) Is ভাই a tatsama like বন্ধু and পরিবার, or a tadbhava? (**A tadbhava** — worn down through Prakrit, not kept whole.)

11.4 বোন (bon) — “sister,” and the root it shares with rice

ভাই (*bhāi*) turned out to be the very word “brother.” This one does not — and where it comes from instead is the surprise this chapter has been saving.

You’ll want to know: বোন

বোন — *bon* — sister

আমার বোন (*āmār bon*) — my sister.

The letters in this word

বোন is ব with the vowel sign ো (*bo*) plus ন (*n*), silent at the end — one plain consonant, no cluster, so the inherent vowel drops just as it did on দুধ and ভাত: *bon*, not *bono*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

English “sister” descends from PIE ***swésōr**. বোন **does not**. It is a tadbhava through Magadhi Prakrit **bahinī*, from Old Indo-Aryan **baghinī* — a doublet of Sanskrit’s own ভগিনী (*bhaginī*), “one with a share,” built on ভগ (*bhaga*), “a share, a portion, good fortune.” And *bhaga* is a noun from the very same verb that named this chapter’s rice two lessons ago: √ভজ् (*√bhaj*, “to divide, to share out”), PIE ***b^heh₂g-**. ভাত is “the portion given”; বোন is “the one with a portion.” Bengali’s word for sister and Bengali’s word for rice are, underneath, cousins. Its word for sister and English’s are not.

The same light touch as last lesson’s দাদা applies here: an older woman may be addressed as দিদি (*didi*, “elder sister”) as a mark of respect, family or not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bon” — sister, no trailing vowel
- “āmār bon” — my sister
- the shared root — “bhaj ... bhāt, bon”
- all four of this chapter’s people — “bôndhu, pôribār, bhāi, bon”
- a count of them, using Chapter 6’s numbers — “āmār ek bhāi. āmār dui bon.” — one brother. two sisters.

Before you move on

Is বোন related to English “sister”? (**No** — different root entirely.) What is it related to instead? (ভাত — both trace to √bhaj, “to share.”) Say “one brother” and “two sisters.” (**Ek bhāi. Dui bon.**) Which of those two numbers keeps a vowel Hindi and Marathi lost? (দুই — the *-i* after the old *dv-*.) And which number wears the chandrabindu? (পাঁচ, five — not needed here, but still the only one that has it.)

Chapter 12

Eye, Mouth, Nose, and Heart

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my eye, my mouth, my nose and my heart in Bengali, and say which of those four words is settled Indo-European, which is a genuinely disputed origin, and which is borrowed whole from Sanskrit with the widest confirmed cousin family in this book.

The chapter closes on হৃদয়, whose root hṛd traces to PIE kṛd- alongside English heart, Greek kardía and Latin cor — the widest, most secure cousin family taught anywhere in this track. The reader names all four body words (chokh, mukh, nāk, hridoy) and states each one’s status: চোখ an ardhatsama half worn down by sound change, মুখ a tatsama with a genuinely disputed

Dravidian-versus-Indo-European origin, নাক a tadbhava with a settled root, হৃদয় a tatsama with a poetic tadbhava twin, হিয়া. It reaches back to rescue Chapter 8’s flapped-ড sound rule and its causative -আনো grammar, neither revisited since Chapter 8.

12.1 চোখ (chokh) — “eye,” built on the root of “to see”

A new chapter, and a new use for Chapter 3’s check-in — the parts of you that check-in is actually asking about.

You’ll want to know: চোখ

চোখ — *chokh* — eye

আমার চোখ (*āmār chokh*) — my eye.

The letters in this word

চোখ is চ with the vowel sign া (cho) plus খ (kh, the puffed sound you already own from খাওয়া), silent at the end — one bare consonant, so no trailing vowel: *chokh*, not *chokho*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

চোখ traces to Sanskrit चक्षुस् (*cakṣus*), “eye” — a noun built directly on √चक्ष् (*√cakṣ*, “to see”), from PIE *k^wek-, “to appear, to see.” The nearest named cousin outside Indo-Aryan is Persian čašm, “eye”; no secure English descendant is claimed for this one. And the word itself has travelled: Old Bengali softened *cakṣus* down through চক্ষু (*caṣṭhu*) and চউখ (*coukh*) to today’s চোখ — half kept from Sanskrit, half worn smooth by three centuries of sound change, which is why this kind of word gets its own name, **ardhatatsama**, “half a tatsama.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chokh” — eye, no trailing vowel
- “āmār chokh” — my eye
- the verb it grew from — “cakṣ ... cakṣus ... chokh”
- the other “see” verb you already own — “dækhā”

Before you move on

Give “my eye” in Bengali. (আমার চোখ.) What Sanskrit verb is চোখ built on? (√*cakṣ*, “to see.”) Is চোখ a tatsama, kept whole like বন্ধু, or fully worn down like ভাই? (Neither — an **ardhatatsama**, half of each.)

12.2 মুখ (mukh) — “mouth, face,” a word two families both claim

চোখ (*chokh*) was half old sound, half new. This word is a full tatsama again — and its own history is a real, unresolved argument among linguists.

You'll want to know: মুখ

মুখ — *mukh* — **mouth, face**

আমার মুখ (*āmār mukh*) — my mouth, my face.

The letters in this word

মুখ is ম with the vowel sign ঁ (*mu*) plus খ (*kh*), silent at the end — one bare consonant again: *mukh*, not *mukho*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

মুখ is a **tatsama**, taken whole from Sanskrit মুখ (*mukha*) — a tadbhava twin, মু (*mu*), also exists, but only buried inside compound words, never standing alone. What makes মুখ worth pausing on is where *mukha* itself came from, and nobody fully agrees. One well-known account, Pokorny's, derives it from **Dravidian**, a language family with no Sanskrit or PIE connection at all. Another, Mayrhofer's, argues for an **Indo-European** source instead, pointing to the word's presence in the Rigveda and in Iranian languages as evidence it is old enough to be inherited rather than borrowed. Both scholars are serious; neither has won. The honest report is that মুখ's deepest root is still an open question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mukh” — mouth, face
- “āmār mukh” — my face
- the two rival accounts — “Dravidian ... or Indo-European”
- an eye, then a mouth — “chokh ... mukh”

Before you move on

Give “my face” in Bengali. (আমার মুখ.) Is মুখ's ultimate origin settled? (**No** — genuinely disputed between a Dravidian and an Indo-European account.) What is মুখ's tadbhava twin, and where does it survive? (মু, **only inside compound words, never**

alone.)

12.3 নাক (nāk) — “nose,” the same word as English’s, worn down differently

মুখ’s origin was an open argument. This one is settled, and it lands somewhere you have seen before.

You’ll want to know: নাক

নাক — *nāk* — nose

আমার নাক (*āmār nāk*) — my nose.

The letters in this word

নাক is ন with the vowel sign া (*nā*) plus ক (*k*), silent at the end: *nāk*, not *nāko*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাক is Sanskrit नस् (*nas*), inherited through Prakrit णक्का — a tadbhava, like ভাই and বোন before it. Its PIE root is **néh₂s-*, and this one is as secure as roots get: it is the direct ancestor of English **nose** itself, and of Latin **nāsus**, which gives English **nasal**. Three languages, one inherited word, three different roads of sound change — Bengali’s road ran the vowel through Prakrit’s *a*, dropped Sanskrit’s final *-s*, and doubled the *k* along the way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāk” — nose
- “āmār nāk” — my nose
- the three cousins — “nāk ... nose ... nāsus”
- three of this chapter’s words — “chokh ... mukh ... nāk”

Before you move on

Give “my nose” in Bengali. (আমার নাক.) Which two English words share নাক’s root directly? (**Nose**, and **nasal** by way of Latin *nāsus*.) Is that link as secure as মুখ’s, or more so? (**More** — নাক’s root is settled; মুখ’s is still argued over.)

12.4 হৃদয় (hridoy) — “heart,” the oldest cousin this book has shown you

Three body words, three different histories — half-worn, disputed, and settled. This last one closes the chapter on the most secure cousin of them all.

You’ll want to know: হৃদয়

হৃদয় — *hridoy* — **heart**

আমার হৃদয় (*āmār hridoy*) — my heart.

The letters in this word

হৃদয় is হ with the vowel sign ্র (hri, the “vocalic r” sign, a vowel Bengali keeps only in words borrowed from Sanskrit) plus দ (*dô*) plus য় (*yô*, a glide, not a plain stop — this is why the word ends audibly, *-doy*, rather than falling silent the way দুধ and নাক did).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হৃদয় is a **tatsama**, Sanskrit হৃদয় (*hṛdaya*) taken whole. A tadbhava twin also exists, হিয়া (*hiya*), but it lives in poetry and song rather than everyday speech — the reverse of মুখ’s pair, where the tatsama is the everyday word. Inside হৃদয় sits হৃদ্ (*hṛd*), and its PIE root is ***kérd-**, “heart” — the direct ancestor of English **heart** itself, Greek **kardía** (English **cardiac**), and Latin **cor** (English **core**, **courage**). Four languages, one root, and nowhere in this book has the family been so wide or so certain.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hridoy” — heart
- “āmār hridoy” — my heart
- the wide family — “hṛd ... heart, kardía, cor”
- all four of this chapter’s words — “chokh, mukh, nāk, hridoy”
- one more word from Chapter 11, sharing this lesson’s warmth of feeling — “bhāi,” brother

Before you move on

Give “my heart” in Bengali. (আমার হৃদয়.) Name three English words that share হৃদয়’s root. (**Heart, cardiac, core** — or **courage**.) Two quick reaches further back: what does the dot under ড় tell you to do, the letter পড়া taught? (**Flap it**, curling the tongue back.) And what does the ending -আনো do to a verb, the way ভাবা showed on দেখা? (**Hands the doing to someone else** — দেখা “see” becomes দেখানো “show.”)

Chapter 13

Please, Sorry, and Welcome

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say please and sorry in Bengali, excuse myself politely, and welcome someone with a word that carries the same 'hither' prefix already met on the verb for coming.

The chapter closes on স্বাগতম, 'welcome', literally 'a good coming': su-, 'good' (PIE h1su-, cousin of Greek eu-), fused by ordinary sandhi onto āgata, 'arrived', which opens with the same ā- 'hither' prefix already met on āsā, this time riding √gam, PIE g^wem-, the secure direct ancestor of English come. The reader gives all four new words of the chapter — doya kore, dukkhito, maf korben, shbagotom — closing the two courtesy concepts, please and sorry, this book had never taught, and a third greeting concept, welcome.

13.1 দয়া করে (doya kore) — “please,” a kindness done

The heart word closed the last chapter. A new one opens on a feeling that starts in the same place — and a word this book has never taught you before now.

You'll want to know: দয়া করে

দয়া করে — *doya kore* — **please**

দয়া করে বসুন (*doya kore bôshun*) — please, sit.

The letters in this word

দয়া is দ (*dô*) plus য় (the glide already met inside হৃদয়) with the vowel sign া (*ā*): *doyā*. করে is ক (*kô*) plus র (*r*) with the vowel sign ে (*e*): *kôre*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দয়া is Sanskrit दया (*dayā*), “compassion, pity.” Most Indo-Europeanists trace its root back to PIE **deh₂-*, “to divide, to apportion” — the same root proposed for Greek *daíomai*, “to divide,” and *dêmos*, “a portion of land, the people,” which English holds without inheriting it directly: **democracy**, **epidemic**, **demographic**. If the comparison is right, compassion and sharing are the same idea at the root — you feel दया for someone by dividing your own good fortune with them, the warmth this book already located in हृदय, the heart.

Grammar Lens: করা wears a new outfit

Noun plus করা already builds a verb — কাজ করা, “to work”; জিজ্ঞাসা করা, “to ask.” Here করা takes a different shape, করে, “having done”: not a full sentence on its own, but a piece that leans on the next word.

shape of করা	job	example
a finite ending (করি, করে, করেন...)	states an action	আমি কাজ করি — I work
করে, unchanged	“having done,” leaning forward	দয়া করে বসুন — please, sit

দয়া করে literally says “having done a kindness, [now do this]” — the kindness is named, then the actual request follows.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “doya” — compassion, then “kore” — having done
- “doya kore bôshun” — please, sit
- the family this word joins — “kāj kôrā ... jījñāsā kôrā ... doya kore”

Before you move on

What does দয়া করে mean literally, piece by piece? (“**Having done a kindness**” — দয়া “compassion” + করে “having done.”) Is করে here a full sentence by itself? (**No** — it leans forward onto the request that follows it.) One quick reach back: what root does দয়া share with a very old disputed argument about **democracy**? (PIE **deh₂-**, “**to divide**” — the same proposed root behind Greek *dêmos*, and behind the warmth হৃদয়, the heart, already carries — two lessons after নাক, the nose, which shares none of it.)

13.2 দুঃখিত (dukkhito) — “sorry,” and a prefix that reaches Greek

Last lesson’s kindness gets a request said politely. This lesson is what you say when the kindness came too late.

You’ll want to know: দুঃখিত

দুঃখিত — *dukkhito* — **sorry**

আমি দুঃখিত (*āmi dukkhito*) — I’m sorry.

The letters in this word

দুঃখিত is দ (*dô*) with the vowel sign ু (*u*), then ঃ — a new mark, the **visarga**, two small stacked dots that add a light breath after the vowel — then খ (*kh*) with the vowel sign ি (*i*), then ত (*t*, silent at the end). Spelled *duḥkhita*, said *dukkhito*: the breath mark softens toward the consonant that follows it rather than staying a separate sound.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দুঃখিত is built on Sanskrit দুঃখ (*duḥkha*), “sorrow, suffering” — the word Buddhism made famous as *dukkha*. Take it apart and one half is certain: দুঃ/দুস্ (*dus-*) means “bad, difficult,” from PIE ***dus-**, the very prefix inside Greek **dys-**: **dystopia**, **dysfunctional**. The other half, খ (*kha*), is where the certainty ends. Sanskrit’s own grammatical tradition explains it as “an axle-hole” — a *duḥkha* journey is a **bad axle-hole**, a rough ride, set against সুখ (*sukha*), “a good axle-hole,”

comfort. It is a vivid story, and it is repeated everywhere. It is also, by the account of modern Sanskritists including Mayrhofer, not a story to trust: the axle-hole reading may be a later folk explanation grafted onto a word whose real root is lost. दुः's cousin is real; थ's is a story, reported and not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dukkhito” — sorry
- “āmi dukkhito” — I’m sorry
- the secure half and its Greek cousin — “dus- ... dystopia”
- last lesson’s request again — “doya kore bôshun”

Before you move on

Say “I’m sorry” in Bengali. (আমি দুঃখিত.) Which half of দুঃখ is a secure PIE prefix, and which English word shares it? (दुः/dus-, “bad” — **dystopia**, by way of Greek *dys*-.) Is the “bad axle-hole” story of थ settled fact? (**No** — a repeated tradition, treated with real skepticism by modern Sanskritists.) Sorrow, like compassion, can weigh somewhere specific — where? (हृदय, the heart.)

13.3 माफ करबेन (maf korben) — “excuse me,” borrowed and softened

Last lesson’s word for “sorry” was a native Sanskrit word. This one is a loanword — the very same loanword Hindi uses in its own “sorry” phrase — and it softens a request in a way you have not met yet.

You’ll want to know: माफ करबेन

माफ करबेन — *maf korben* — **excuse me**

माफ करबेन, एकट्ठु जायगा देबेन? (*maf korben, êktu jāyga debên?*) — excuse me, could you make a little room?

The letters in this word

মাফ is ম (*mô*) with া (*ā*) plus ফ (*ph*, the puffed *p*). Notice what is missing: Hindi marks this same borrowed sound with a small dot under its own letter for *pha*, a *nuqtā*, to write a dedicated letter for *f*. Bengali’s script has no such mark at all — ফ alone serves for both the native puffed *p* and this borrowed *f*, and only habit tells a reader which one a given word means.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

মাফ is not Bengali, and not Sanskrit: it is borrowed, by way of Persian, from Arabic *’afw*, “to pardon, to wipe a wrong away.” Hindi borrowed the identical word for the identical job. Bengali also keeps a formal, Sanskritic cousin for the same idea, ক্ষমা করবেন, from ক্ষমা (*kṣamā*), “patience, forbearance” — the everyday loan and the bookish native word side by side, the same split Hindi keeps.

Grammar Lens: the future, asked to be gentle

The tea-offering pattern you already own reuses a **present** verb — আপনি খান — to make a request. করবেন does the same job with a different tense: it is the plain **future**, “you will do,” not a command at all by its grammar, and yet its job here is exactly a request — a third shape for করা, beside last lesson’s participle করে.

tense used	what it does	example
present habitual	states, and doubles as a request	আপনি খান — you eat / please eat
future	states, and doubles as a <i>softer</i> request	মাফ করবেন — you will excuse / please excuse

The future’s distance is what buys the softness: asking rather than telling, even grammatically.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “maf korben” — excuse me
- the two soft requests compared — “chā khān ... maf korben”

Before you move on

Where does মাফ come from? (**Arabic** 'afw, “to pardon,” by **way of Persian** — the same loan Hindi’s own “sorry” phrase uses.) What tense is করবেন, and why does that make it gentler than a command? (**Future** — “you will do,” asking rather than telling.)

13.4 স্বাগতম (shbagotom) — “welcome,” a good arrival

This chapter has taught what to say after a mistake. It closes on what to say before anything goes wrong at all — a word built on the same “hither” you have carried since the verb for **coming**.

You’ll want to know: স্বাগতম

স্বাগতম — *shbagotom* — **welcome**

আমাদের বাড়িতে স্বাগতম (*āmāder bārite shbagotom*) — welcome to our house.

The letters in this word

স্বাগতম is স্ব (a conjunct, স joined straight to ব with no vowel between — *sbô*, tilted by the same *s*→*sh* habit every Sanskrit word in this book has shown) plus া (ā), then গ (*gô*), ত (*tô*), and ম (*mô*, keeping its own inherent vowel at the very end): *shbā-go-to-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

স্বাগতম is Sanskrit স্বাগতম (*svāgatam*), built from two pieces fused together. The second piece, আগত (*āgata*), “arrived, come,” opens with the very same আ-, “hither,” that আসা’s own lesson already named — except here it rides a different verb, √গম্ (*√gam*, “to go, to come”), not আসা’s own unsettled stem. √**gam** is PIE ***g^wem-**, and this root is about as secure as roots get: it is the direct ancestor of English **come**, and, by way of Latin **venīre**, of **advent** and **convene** too. The first piece, সু- (*su-*, “good”), loses its vowel to the glide ব when the next syllable also opens with a vowel — ordinary Sanskrit sandhi, the same trade সু- plus আগত makes every time: *svāgata*. সু- is PIE ***h₁su-**,

cousin of Greek **eu-**, the “good” inside **eulogy** and **euphoria**. Put the pieces back together: স্বাগতম is, literally, “a good coming.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shbagotom” — welcome
- “āmāder bāṛite shbagotom” — welcome to our house
- the shared prefix — “ā-, hither” — on āsā, then on āgata
- the two secure cousins — “gam ... come” and “su- ... eu-”

Before you move on

Give “welcome” in Bengali. (স্বাগতম.) What does স্বাগতম mean, piece by piece? (“**Good**” plus “**come**” — a good arrival.) Which prefix does it share with আসা, and on a different verb this time? (আ-, “**hither**” — on √gam here, not আসা’s own uncertain stem.) Run this chapter’s three other new words back: a kindness done, a word for sorrow, and a borrowed pardon. (দয়া করে, দুঃখিত, মাপ করবেন.) One more reach: what tense softened that pardon into a request? (**Future** — করবেন, “you will do.”)

Chapter 14

Five Colors

Modes: 👁 eyes (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five colors in Bengali and say which came from Persian, which from Sanskrit, and which is the one color where Bengali and Hindi genuinely parted ways.

The chapter closes on সবুজ, 'green', a second Persian loan (sabz, the same root behind Hindi and Urdu's sabzī, 'vegetable') that sets beside লাল's own Persian gem-name. The reader names all five colors — lāl, nīl, kālo, shādā, shôbuḡ — and sorts them by origin: two Persian loans, two Sanskrit words, and one worn down by sound change, a more even split between inherited and borrowed than food or family showed.

14.1 লাল (lal) — “red,” a gemstone’s name first

A new small set of words: not people, not verbs, not places, but the colors of the things around you — starting with the one Bengali did not invent for itself.

You’ll want to know: লাল

লাল — lāl — red

লাল চা (lāl chā) — “red tea,” the everyday way to ask for tea without milk.

The letters in this word

লাল is ল (lô) with the vowel sign া (ā), plus a second ল (l, silent at the end): *lāl*, one long vowel between two of the same consonant.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

লাল is a Persian loan, from Persian *la' l*, which named one specific thing first: a deep-red gemstone, a ruby or a spinel. Only later did the gem's name widen into the ordinary word for the color itself. Bengali did not build this word out of its own materials, and it did not borrow it alone — Hindi's own word for red is this identical Persian loan, carried into both languages by the same jewelers' trade routes rather than independently invented twice.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “lāl” — red
- “lāl chā” — tea without milk
- what it named first — “a ruby, not a color”

Before you move on

What did লাল originally name, before it meant “red”? (**A deep red gemstone.**) Did Bengali and Hindi each invent this word separately? (**No** — both borrowed the identical Persian loan.) One more reach: give the polite excuse-me again, and its softening tense. (মাফ করবেন — **the future**, “you will do.”)

14.2 নীল (nil) — “blue,” and a word that only looks like “indigo”

The last color was foreign, borrowed whole. This one is Sanskrit's own — and it comes with a famous false friend worth clearing up honestly.

You'll want to know: नील

नील — *nīl* — blue

नील जल (*nīl jôl*) — blue water.

The letters in this word

नील is न (*nô*) with the vowel sign ी (a long *ī*, the same sound as the short *i* but held longer), plus ल (*l*, silent at the end): *nīl*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नील is Sanskrit नील (*nīla*), “dark blue” — also the name of the **indigo plant** and the dye made from it, the same root Hindi's own *nīlā* carries. One difference is worth stating plainly: Hindi's *nīlā* changes shape, *nīlā/nīlī*, for the noun it describes; नील **never does**, one form whether the water, the sky, or the dress is blue.

Here is the honest, careful version of a famous connection. English “**indigo**” does **not** come from *nīla* by sound change. It comes from **Greek** *indikón*, simply “the Indian [thing]” — because Greek and Roman traders imported the dye *from* India and named it for its source. *Nīla* and “indigo” are not the same word wearing two disguises; they are two **separate** words for the same dye, linked by the history of trade, not by descent from a shared root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nīl*” — blue
- “*nīl jôl*” — blue water
- one form, always — “*nīl*,” never *nīlā* or *nīlī*

Before you move on

Does नील change shape for the noun it describes, the way Hindi's *nīlā* does? (**No** — one form, always.) Does English “indigo” come directly from नील/*nīla*? (**No** — it is Greek *indikón*, “the Indian thing”; the two words are linked by trade, not by sound change.)

Give “welcome” once more. (स्वागतम्.)

14.3 कालो (kalo) — “black,” the same word as “time”

Blue carried a false friend. This color hides something bigger inside it: the very word Sanskrit uses for time itself, and for death.

You’ll want to know: कालो

कालो — *kālo* — black

कालो चा (*kālo chā*) — black tea.

The letters in this word

कालो is क (*kô*) with the vowel sign ा (*ā*), plus ल (*l*) with the vowel sign ो (*o*): *kā-lo*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कालो is built on Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), a word that covers both “**black, dark**” and “**time.**” Sanskrit’s own tradition ties the two together poetically — time devours everything, and that devouring is imagined as dark — and the same word names the fierce goddess **Kālī** (“the black/dark one”) and stands as an epithet of **Yama**, the god of death. Hindi’s own *kālā* carries the identical root and the identical story. Be honest, though: whether “black” and “time” are truly **one and the same root**, or two separate ancient words that poetry and theology later **fused** into a single idea, is a real, still-debated question among linguists — the cultural connection is certain; the precise etymology underneath it is not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kālo*” — black

- “kālo chā” — black tea
- what else কাল means — “time,” and by extension, death

Before you move on

What does কালো’s root, কাল, also mean, besides “black”? (**Time** — and by extension, death; the same word names the goddess Kālī and Yama’s epithet Kāla.) Is it settled that “black” and “time” are the same root? (**No** — the cultural link is real and ancient, but linguists still debate whether it is one true root or two words later fused.)

14.4 সাদা (shada) — “white,” the color where the cousins part ways

Every color so far has matched Hindi’s, word for word. This one does not — and it is the more interesting choice for it.

You’ll want to know: সাদা

সাদা — *shādā* — **white**

সাদা দুধ (*shādā dudh*) — white milk.

The letters in this word

সাদা is স (*sô*, carrying its familiar tilt to *sh*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*), plus দ (*dô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*) again: *shā-dā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

সাদা is usually traced to Sanskrit श्वेत (*śveta*), “white,” worn down through Middle Bengali into today’s everyday word — a **tadbhava**, the same road মুখ’s own twin travelled, only in reverse: here the tadbhava is the common word and the **tatsama**, শ্বেত (*śveto*), survives kept whole inside compounds, like শ্বেতাঙ্গ (*śvetāngo*), “pale-skinned.” This is the one color where Bengali and Hindi genuinely part ways. Every other color word met so far — the borrowed gem-name, the indigo plant, the time-word — Bengali and Hindi share outright. For white, Hindi replaced its own Sanskrit-derived word with a **Persian** loan, *safed*. Bengali did not: it kept the native word as its everyday

one, and the Persian loan never took hold here the way it did next door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shādā” — white
- “shādā dudh” — white milk
- the compound cousin — “śveto ... śvetāngo”

Before you move on

Is সাদা a tatsama, kept whole, or a tadbhava, worn down by sound change? (**A tadbhava** — its tatsama twin, শ্বেত, survives only in compounds, the same split মুখ’s own twin showed.) Of the colors met so far, which one did Hindi replace with a Persian loan while Bengali kept the native word? (**White** — Hindi’s *safed* against Bengali’s সাদা.)

14.5 সবুজ (shobuj) — “green,” and five colors, counted up

One color left, and it is a second loan from the same language that gave লাল its gem — but this time the loan travelled somewhere you already have a word for.

You’ll want to know: সবুজ

সবুজ — *shôbuj* — **green**

সবুজ চা (*shôbuj chā*) — green tea.

The letters in this word

সবুজ is স (*sô*, tilted to *sh*, keeping its own inherent vowel since nothing joins it) plus ব (*bô*) with the vowel sign ু (*u*), plus জ (*j*, silent at the end): *shô-bu-j*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

সবুজ is borrowed from Persian **sabz**, “green” — the very same Persian word that gave Hindi and Urdu their word for “vegetable,” **sabzī**, literally “the green things.” লাল’s own Persian gem-name arrived by the same route, from the same trading world, into a different corner of the vocabulary.

Step back and count the five colors this small set has taught: two Persian loans (লাল, সবুজ), two Sanskrit words kept recognizably close to their root (নীল, কালো), and one worn down by sound change (সাদা). A more even split between inherited and borrowed than the food words or the family words showed — color, it turns out, came into Bengali from everywhere at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shôbuj” — green
- “shôbuj chā” — green tea
- all five colors — “lāl, nīl, kālō, shādā, shôbuj”
- the two Persian loans, then the two Sanskrit words, then the one worn down — “lāl, shôbuj ... nīl, kālō ... shādā”

Before you move on

What Persian word gives both সবুজ and Hindi’s word for “vegetable”? (**sabz**, “**green**” — Hindi’s *sabzī* is literally “the green things.”) Of the five colors, how many are Persian loans, how many are Sanskrit words, and how many are worn down by sound change? (**Two, two, and one** — লাল and সবুজ; নীল and কালো; সাদা.) Name all five colors, in order. (লাল, নীল, কালো, সাদা, সবুজ.)

Chapter 15

Cloth, Shirt, Sari, and Glasses

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) 🖐 Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name cloth, a shirt, a sari and glasses in Bengali, and say which word English borrowed directly and which is built on the same Persian word already met for 'eye'.

The chapter closes on চশমা, 'glasses', built on Persian chashm, 'eye' — the very word চোখ's own lesson once named as its only cousin outside the family, here turned into 'eye-thing'. The reader names all four garments — kāpor, jāmā, shāri, chôshmā — states that শাড়ি reached English as a direct modern loanword rather than through a shared ancient root, and reaches back to rescue the dative construction and ভালোবাসা, unrevisited since they were taught.

15.1 কাপড় (kapor) — “cloth,” a word five languages share

Five colors named. Now the things they color, starting with the plainest word for cloth itself — and a sound you have not needed since the verb for reading.

You'll want to know: কাপড়

কাপড় — kāpor — cloth, clothing

সাদা কাপড় (shādā kapor) — white cloth.

The letters in this word

কাপড় is ক (*kô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*), plus প (*pô*), plus ড — the flapped letter, the same curled-tongue sound the reading verb needed, silent-final here: *kā-po-r*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কাপড় traces to Sanskrit कर्पाट (*karpāṭa*), “rag, old cloth.” Here the honesty runs deeper than usual: even Sanskrit’s own dictionaries label *karpāṭa* a **deśī** word — homegrown vernacular vocabulary that was already sitting inside classical Sanskrit rather than inherited from any older reconstructed root. No further ancestor is claimed for it at all. What makes it worth teaching anyway is how far it travelled sideways: the identical word, worn down by the same kind of sound change, gives Hindi *kaprā*, Marathi *kaṇḍā*, Gujarati *kaṇḍū*, and Punjabi *kaprā* — five Indo-Aryan languages sharing one root together, none of them borrowing from the others.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kāpoṛ” — cloth
- “shādā kāpoṛ” — white cloth
- the flap, again — “poṛā ... kāpoṛ”
- the family sharing this root — “kāpoṛ ... kaprā ... kaṇḍā”

Before you move on

Does কাপড়’s root, *karpāṭa*, trace back to a reconstructed PIE ancestor? (**No** — Sanskrit’s own dictionaries call it a homegrown, *deśī* word.) Name two other Indo-Aryan languages that share this exact root. (**Hindi’s** *kaprā*, **Marathi’s** *kaṇḍā* — or Gujarati’s *kaṇḍū*, or Punjabi’s *kaprā*.)

15.2 জামা (jama) — “shirt,” a third word from Persian

Cloth in general, now a specific garment — and Persian, again, supplies the word.

You’ll want to know: জামা

জামা — *jāmā* — shirt

লাল জামা (*lāl jāmā*) — a red shirt.

The letters in this word

জামা is জ (*jô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*), plus ম (*mô*) with the vowel sign া (*ā*) again: *jā-mā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

জামা is a Persian loan, *jāma*, “robe, garment” — carried into Hindi and Urdu as the identical word, *jāmā*. Count it up: of the clothing and color words in this small set, three now trace to Persian rather than Sanskrit — লাল, সবুজ, and জামা. Bengali’s everyday wardrobe vocabulary leans on the same trading world its colors did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*jāmā*” — shirt
- “*lāl jāmā*” — a red shirt
- the three Persian loans so far — “*lāl ... shôbuj ... jāmā*”

Before you move on

Where does জামা come from? (**Persian *jāma*, “robe, garment,”** the identical word Hindi and Urdu also use.) How many of this set’s clothing and color words now trace to Persian? (**Three** — লাল, সবুজ, জামা.)

15.3 শাড়ি (shari) — “sari,” a word English simply borrowed

Every English cousin this book has traced so far has been buried deep — a shared PIE root, worn down over thousands of years past recognizing. This word’s road into English was much shorter.

You’ll want to know: শাড়ি

শাড়ি — *shāri* — sari

লাল শাড়ি (*lāl shāri*) — a red sari.

The letters in this word

শাড়ি opens with শ — a second letter for an *s*-family sound, a different one from স. Sanskrit distinguished three of these (স, শ, and a third, ষ); modern Bengali speech has merged them into one sound, but the spelling keeps them apart. Then া (*ā*), ড় (the flap you now know from কাপড়), and ি (*i*): *shā-ri*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

শাড়ি traces to Sanskrit शाटी (*śāṭī*), “a strip of cloth, a garment,” worn down through Middle Indic साडी (*sāḍī*) into Bengali and Hindi’s shared *śāri/sāri*. Here is the unusual part: every English cousin this book has traced so far — heart, nose, bind, come — went underground for thousands of years, worn down by sound change on both ends until only a shared ancient root connects them. This word took a different road. It entered English directly, in the modern era, as an ordinary borrowed word: “**sari**.” No PIE root, no centuries of drift — just a garment’s name, carried whole into another language’s dictionary.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “shāri” — sari
- “lāl shāri” — a red sari
- the second *s*-letter — “শ, beside স”

- three garments so far — “kāpoṛ ... jāmā ... shāri”

Before you move on

How did শাড়ি reach English — through a shared ancient root, worn down over millennia, or as a direct modern loanword? (**A direct loanword** — “sari,” borrowed whole, no PIE root involved.) How many distinct *s*-family letters did Sanskrit distinguish, now merged in Bengali speech? (**Three** — স, শ, ষ.)

15.4 চশমা (choshma) — “glasses,” built on an old cousin’s name

Three garments named. This one closes the chapter by returning to the very body part the eye lesson once traced to a single named Persian cousin — and building something new out of it.

You’ll want to know: চশমা

চশমা — *chôshmā* — glasses

আমার চশমা (*āmār chôshmā*) — my glasses.

The letters in this word

চশমা is spelled চ (*chô*) + শ (*shô*, the second *s*-letter শাড়ি just introduced) + ম (*mô*) + া (*ā*) — four sounds by the spelling. Ordinary speech thins it to three: *chôsh-mā*, not *chô-sho-mā* — an everyday shortening this particular loanword has settled into.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

চশমা is built on Persian চশম (*chashm*), “eye” — the exact word the eye lesson once named as চোখ’s only named cousin outside the Indo-Aryan family, with no secure English descendant claimed for চোখ itself. চশমা takes that word and adds a suffix that turns “eye” into “eye-thing”: **spectacles**, the thing that sits in front of your eyes. Bengali did not build this the way it built জিজ্ঞাসা করা or সাহায্য করা, by hanging করা on a noun; it took a ready-made South Asian coinage on a Persian root, the same formation Hindi and Urdu also use.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “chôshmā” — glasses
- “āmār chôshmā” — my glasses
- the eye it is built on — “chashm ... chôshmā”
- all four garments of this chapter — “kāpor, jāmā, shārī, chôshmā”

Before you move on

What Persian word is চশমা built on, and where did this book meet it before? (**Chashm**, “eye” — named as চোখ’s only cousin outside the family.) Say all five colors and all four garments this small set has now taught. (লাল, নীল, কালো, সাদা, সবুজ; কাপড়, জামা, শাড়ি, চশমা.) Two reaches further back, to close out: who is the subject of *āmār bhālo lāge*, “I like it”? (**Not you** — the good is, the same shape as *āmār chôshmā*, “to me, glasses.”) And is *āmi bhālobāsi*, “I love,” built the same inverted way? (**No** — loving takes you as subject; liking happens to you.)

Chapter 16

Hanging From the Head-Line, One Piece at a Time

Modes: ✍ pen (10) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can write nine Bengali pieces from memory — six consonants, a vowel sign, its independent twin and the hasanta — and read the words for no and the greeting by assembling them from those pieces, including the greeting's conjunct.

The greeting assembled from seven pieces the reader can each write from memory, including the conjunct and the letter written s but said sh, and introducing nothing new.

16.1 ন — the consonant na

Nothing is assumed but the words you can already say. This chapter turns them into words you can read.

Script

Bengali is an **abugida**: a consonant already carries a vowel, and you write a vowel mark only when you want a different one.

ন

Now the part that catches every reader who comes to Bengali from Hindi or Sanskrit. The inherent vowel here is **not** *a*. It is **ô** — the vowel of English *awe*, rounded and open. So this letter alone is **nô**, not *na*.

Devanagari's bare consonant says *ka*; Bengali's says *kô*. Same family, same system, **different default**. It is one of the first things that makes Bengali sound like Bengali rather than like Hindi read aloud.

Look at the top of the shape: a **horizontal bar**, and in running text it joins up across a whole word so the writing hangs from a line — the same head-line Devanagari has, and the one Gujarati erases.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ন
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What vowel does a bare Bengali consonant carry? (*ô*, the vowel of *awe* — not *a*.) And what does Devanagari's carry instead? (*a*.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.2 া — the vowel sign that replaces the inherent vowel

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

To get a different vowel you **replace** the inherent one with a mark called a **mātrā**.

া

A single upright stroke standing to the **right** of its consonant, dropping from the head-line. Attached, it swaps the inherent *ô* for a long open *a*.

ন + া → না

na — and that is the word for **no**, which you have been saying since your first lesson.

One consonant and one mark, and a word you could already say became a word you can **read**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* া
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What does a mātrā do to the inherent vowel? (**Replaces** it.) What word did those two pieces make? (না — *na*, “no”.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.3 আ — the same vowel standing alone

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

The mark you just learned only works **attached to a consonant**. So what do you write when a word **begins** with that vowel?

A different character:

আ

That is the same **a** sound, but as an **independent vowel** — a full letter that stands on its own at the start of a word.

These are two different characters, not two styles of one. A font, a keyboard and this book all treat them as entirely separate, and confusing them is the commonest spelling error in every Indic script.

What decides which one you write is **position**, not sound:

- আ begins a word.
- া rides on a consonant.

Two words you already say begin with this letter — the one for *I see you later* and the one for *all right*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* আ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Which of the two starts a word? (আ.) Which rides on a consonant? (ই.) Are they the same character? (**No** — two separate characters, one sound.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.4 হ — the consonant ha

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

হ

hô — the *h* of English *hat*, plus the inherent vowel you now know is **ô** rather than *a*.

No new machinery: every rule you hold applies unchanged. **New shapes are coming; new rules are not.**

You have been saying this letter since your first lesson — it opens the word for *yes*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* হ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What is the inherent vowel in হ? (ô.) How many new rules did this lesson add? (**None.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.5 ম — the consonant ma

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ম

mô — the *m* of English *met*, plus the inherent vowel.

Three consonants now. Say them in the order you met them, each with the vowel nobody wrote:

ন হ ম

nô, hô, mô. Notice you are saying *aw* three times, not *ah*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ম
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Say the three consonants you hold, each with its inherent vowel.

(*nô, hô, mô*.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.6 ঞ — the consonant that is written s and said sh

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ঞ

Here the letter and the sound part company, and it is worth knowing early.

This letter descends from the Sanskrit *s*, and every transliteration writes it *s*. **In Bengali it is normally pronounced *sh*** — the *sh* of English *shoe*.

So the word you say as *nomosh-kar* is written with what looks like an *s*. The spelling records the word's Sanskrit ancestry; the pronunciation records what Bengali did with it afterwards. **Both are true, and the script keeps the older one.**

English does exactly this with *knight* and *through*. Every literary language accumulates spellings that outlive their sounds.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ঞ
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

How is ঞ written in transliteration, and how is it said? (Written *s*, said *sh*.) Why the difference? (The spelling keeps the **Sanskrit ancestry**; the sound moved on.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.7 ক — the consonant ka

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

ক

kô — the *k* of English *skip*, with **no puff of breath** after it.

Hold a palm in front of your mouth and say English *kit*: you feel air. Say *skip*: you do not. **This is the second one.** Bengali has a separate letter for the breathy version, and swapping them changes the word — so a difference English treats as an accident, this script writes down.

Five consonants, one mātrā, one independent vowel. One piece of machinery left.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ক
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

Is ক the *k* of *kit* or of *skip*? (Of **skip** — no puff of air.) Does the script care? (**Yes** — the breathy one is a different letter.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.8 ং — the mark that DELETES the inherent vowel and fuses two consonants

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

The inherent vowel is a nuisance when you do not want it. If a word presses two consonants together with no vowel between them, writing them plainly would insert an *ô* that is not there.

So there is a mark that removes it:

ং

Bengali calls it the **hasanta** — Devanagari calls the same thing a *virama*. It sits under a consonant and means: *no vowel here*.

Then something happens that no European alphabet does. A consonant stripped of its vowel **fuses** with the one after it into a single joined shape, a **conjunct**:

স + ং + ক → ঙ্ক

One cluster. **Conjuncts are not new characters to memorise** — they are two you already know, joined. Bengali's are more thoroughly fused than Devanagari's, so some take a moment to take apart, but the principle does not change.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ং
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

What does the hasanta do? (**Removes the inherent vowel.**)
 What is Devanagari's name for the same mark? (The **virama**.)
 And are conjuncts new letters? (**No** — two known letters, fused.)
 Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.9 র — the last consonant of the greeting

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

র

rô — a light tap of the tongue, closer to the *r* of Spanish *pero* than to any English *r*.

That is the last piece. Everything the greeting needs is now something you can write from memory.

Your turn

- *Write it:* র
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

How is র made? (A **light tap**, not an English *r*.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

16.10 নমস্কার — seven pieces, all of them already yours

Write the piece from the previous lesson before adding another.

Script

Nothing new is introduced here. Every piece below is one you can write.

ন + ম + স + ্ + ক + া + র → নমস্কার

Read it the way you built it:

- ন — *nô*, inherent vowel
- ম — *mô*, inherent vowel
- ঙ্গ — the conjunct: the *s*-letter with its vowel removed, fused to *kô*

- া — the mātrā, making that piece *ka*
- র — *rô*

nô-mosh-kar — and notice the *sh*, from a letter written *s*.

Count what it took: **six consonants, one mātrā, one independent vowel and one hasanta**. With them you can read *no* and the greeting, and every consonant you meet from here obeys rules you already hold.

Bengali has around forty more letters. It does not have any more **systems**.

Your turn

- *Write it:* নমস্কার
- *Read it:* every piece this chapter has given you so far, in order

Before you move on

How many new pieces were in this lesson? (**None**.) What is ঙ made of? (The **s**-letter with its vowel removed, joined to ক.) And what still remains to learn — rules, or shapes? (**Shapes**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

Chapter 17

Five More Pieces, Six More Words

Modes: ✍ pen (11) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read six Bengali words I already say — নাম, আমি, লাল, তিন, তুমি and কেমন — by adding five pieces to the nine I already write, and I can say why a vowel sign written in front of a consonant is still spoken after it.

The six words of the chapter read back in one pass, introducing no new shape — and the count that shows why three of the five additions being vowel signs was worth more than three more consonants.

17.1 নাম — a whole word, read, with nothing new in it

Write the greeting again before starting. Every piece in it is one you made from memory.

Script

The word for *name* has been said aloud since the second chapter. Here it is on the page, and there is nothing in it you have not already written:

ন + া + ম → নাম

- ন — *nô*, carrying its own vowel
- া — the *mātrā*, which throws that vowel out and puts *ā* in its place, so the piece now says *nā*

- ম — *mô*

nām. Say it with the mouth open on the first syllable and closed on the second, and you have the word you have been using since আমার নাম — “*my name.*”

Look at the top of the three shapes. The head-line is one unbroken bar across the whole word. That bar is why a Bengali word looks like a single object rather than three, and it is also the reason a reader coming from English keeps trying to break it in the wrong places: the bar is decoration on the letters, not a boundary between them.

One more falls out of the same nine pieces. ন + া + ক is *nāk* — the word for *nose* from the chapter on the face.

Your turn

- Read it: নাম
- Read it: নাক
- Write it: নাম

Before you move on

How many new pieces were in this lesson? (**None.**) What does the mātrā do to the vowel a consonant already carries? (**Replaces** it.) And what is the bar along the top — a letter boundary, or part of the letters? (**Part of the letters.**)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.2 ি — the i-sign, written before the consonant it is heard after

Read নাম aloud before adding another piece.

Script

The mātrā া replaced a consonant’s vowel with ā and sat to the right of it. Here is the sign that puts i there instead:

ি

The sound is the *i* of English *bit* — short, and never the *ee* of *feet*.

Now the part worth slowing down for. This sign is written **to the left** of the consonant it belongs to, and spoken **to the right** of it. Take ম *mô* and add it:

ম + ি → মি — said *mi*, not *im*

The hook sits in front on the page; the vowel lands behind in the mouth. Nothing about the shape tells you that, and nothing about the sound tells you either. It is a habit of the writing system, held on to from the Brahmi script every Indian abugida descends from, and Devanagari does exactly the same thing.

A reader who tries to sound out the marks in the order the eye meets them will get this word backwards every time. Read the consonant first, then the sign in front of it.

Your turn

- Write it: ি
- Write it: মি
- Read it: নাম

Before you move on

Which side of its consonant is ি written on? (**The left.**) Which side is it heard on? (**The right.**) And is the sound the *i* of *bit* or of *feet*? (Of ***bit***.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.3 আমি — the word for I, and two more that come free with it

Write ি once, and say which side of its consonant it goes on.

Script

আ + ম + ি → আমি

- আ — the independent vowel, standing on its own because nothing comes before it to hang a sign on
- ম — *mô*
- ি — written in front of that ম, heard after it

āmi — *I*. The word from the third chapter, the one that came down from Sanskrit *asmī* and is cousin to English *am*.

Watch what the sign does to the eye. On the page the order runs আ, then the hook, then ম. In the mouth it runs ā, then m, then i. The middle two swap. This is the single most common stumble for a new reader of any Indian script, and the cure is mechanical: **find the consonant, say it, then say the sign leaning on its left.**

Two more words are now readable with nothing added.

ক + ি → কি — *ki*, the question word: *what*

আ + স + ি → আসি — *āsi*, the goodbye from the first chapter that means “*I’ll come again*”

Three words out of one sign. That is what a working set does.

Your turn

- *Read it:* আমি
- *Read it:* কি
- *Read it:* আসি
- *Write it:* আমি

Before you move on

In আমি, which two sounds swap between the page and the mouth? (**The m and the i.**) Why does আ stand in its own full shape here? (Because **nothing comes before it** to carry a sign.) And what does আসি mean? (“*I’ll come again*” — the **goodbye**.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.4 ল — the consonant la

Read আমি and কি aloud before adding a new shape.

Script

ল

লô — the *l* of English *let*, made with the tongue-tip on the back of the top teeth rather than on the ridge behind them. English puts it a little further back and lets the tongue-body sag, which is what makes an English *l* at the end of a word sound thick. Bengali keeps it forward and light in every position.

The shape hangs from the head-line like the rest, with a loop at the bottom left and a stroke that turns back on itself.

Bengali has **one** letter for this sound. That is worth naming, because the south of the subcontinent does not: Tamil and Malayalam each carry three distinct l-letters for three distinct tongue positions, and a Bengali reader meeting a Tamil place-name is looking at distinctions their own script never had to record. Going the other way is easier — a southern reader has one Bengali shape to learn where they had three.

Add the mātrā and the piece says *lā*:

ল + া → লা

Your turn

- Write it: ল
- Write it: লা
- Read it: আমি

Before you move on

Where does the tongue go for Bengali ল — on the teeth or on the ridge behind them? (**On the teeth.**) How many l-letters does Bengali have? (**One.**) And how many do Tamil and Malayalam have? (**Three.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.5 লাল — red, and the day-word that runs both ways

Write ল once, then say where the tongue sits for it.

Script

ল + া + ল → লাল

The same letter twice, with the mātrā between them. The first ল takes the sign and becomes *lā*; the second keeps its own inherent vowel, which at the end of a word is barely voiced at all. So the word comes out **lāl** — one syllable to an English ear, the colour **red**, the Persian gem-word from the chapter on colours.

Swap the first shape for ক and you get another word already in your mouth:

ক + া + ল → কাল

kāl — the word that means **tomorrow** and **yesterday** both, and which the farewell chapter used in *kāl dākhā hōbe*. Bengali does not think the two days need separate names; the distance from today is what the word records, and the direction comes from the verb.

Two words, three pieces each, one shape different between them. Reading is starting to be recombination rather than recognition.

Your turn

- Read it: লাল
- Read it: কাল
- Read it: আমি
- Write it: লাল

Before you move on

Why is the second ল in লাল not said *lô*? (Its inherent vowel is **barely voiced at the end of a word**.) And which two days does কাল cover? (**Yesterday and tomorrow** — both.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.6 ত — the consonant ta, the dental one

Read লাল and কাল aloud before adding a new shape.

Script

ত

tô — and the tongue goes somewhere an English speaker does not put it. Press the tip flat against the **back of the top front teeth**, so the contact is on enamel, and release. That is this letter.

The English *t* of *top* is made a centimetre further back, on the ridge behind the teeth. Bengali has a **separate letter** for that further-back sound, and it arrives later in this chapter's family. The two are not accents of one letter: they spell different words. So an English *t* dropped into a Bengali word is not a slight accent — it is the other letter, and the listener hears it as one.

The test is physical, not auditory. Say English *top* and feel where the tongue lands. Slide it forward onto the teeth and say it again. The second one is ত.

With the mātrā:

ত + া → তা

Your turn

- Write it: ত
- Write it: তা
- Read it: লাল

Before you move on

Where does the tongue touch for ত — the teeth or the ridge behind them? (**The teeth.**) Does Bengali have a second, further-back t? (**Yes**, a separate letter.) And is using the English one a small accent, or a different letter? (**A different letter.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.7 তিন — three, read

Write ত, then write ি, and say which side of a consonant the second one goes on.

Script

ত + ি + ন → তিন

Read it the way the mouth needs it, not the way the eye meets it:

- ত — the dental *t*, tongue on the teeth
- ি — leaning on that ত from the left, heard after it
- ন — *nô*, its inherent vowel almost silent at the end

tin — *three*, counted since the numbers chapter.

The hook in front of ত is the same trap as আমি, and it will keep being the same trap until the hand has written it twenty times. On the page: hook, t, n. In the mouth: t, i, n.

This word is also about as old as words get. Sanskrit *tri*, Latin *trēs*, Greek *treîs*, English *three* — the numbers chapter set that out, and the point here is only that you can now meet it on a page in Kolkata instead of in a table.

Your turn

- *Read it:* তিন
- *Read it:* লাল
- *Write it:* তিন

Before you move on

In তিন, is the hook read before or after the ত? (**After** — it is only written before.) And what does the word mean? (**Three**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.8 ু — the u-sign, hanging below the line

Read তিন aloud, and say which piece the eye meets first.

Script

Two vowel signs so far: া to the right, ি to the left. Here is the third direction.

ু

The sound is the *u* of English *put*, short and rounded — never the *oo* of *food*.

It is written **underneath** its consonant, tucked into the bottom of the shape:

ত + ু → তু — said *tu*

That is the whole of the news, and it matters more than it sounds. A script whose marks go above, below, left and right of a letter cannot be read as a line of beads. The consonant is the anchor; everything else is furniture arranged around it. Find the anchor first, then look around it, and the reading order stops being a guess.

The hand has to learn it too: the stroke starts at the foot of the consonant and curls, and it must not drift so far left that it looks like it belongs to the letter before.

Your turn

- Write it: ু
- Write it: তু
- Read it: তিন

Before you move on

Which side of its consonant does ু sit on? (**Underneath.**) Is the sound the *u* of *put* or the *oo* of *food*? (Of ***put.***) And which piece of a written syllable is the anchor? (**The consonant.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.9 তুমি — the familiar you, read

Write ু and ি, and say which way each of them faces.

Script

ত + ু + ম + ি → তুমি

Four pieces, and the two vowel signs go to two different places:

- ত with ু slung underneath it — *tu*
- ম with ি standing in front of it — *mi*

tumi — the middle rung of Bengali’s three-way *you*: **tui** for a child or a brother, **tumi** for a friend, **āpni** for a stranger or an elder. This is the one a learner uses most and the one that will be used back at them.

Notice what the word looks like as an object. Above the letters runs the head-line; below the first letter hangs the u-sign; between the letters stands the i-hook. Three levels on one word. The eye that only scans along the head-line will miss half of it — Bengali reading is a scan of a **band**, not of a line.

Say আমি তুমি aloud, the two pronouns together, and hear that each is two light syllables with no stress worth speaking of. Bengali does not lean on one syllable the way English does.

Your turn

- *Read it:* তুমি
- *Read it:* আমি
- *Write it:* তুমি

Before you move on

In তুমি, where is the u-sign? (**Under the first letter.**) Where is the i-sign? (**In front of the second.**) And which of the three yous is তুমি? (The **familiar** one — for a friend.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.10 ে — the e-sign, standing in front

Read তুমি, and name where each of its two vowel signs sits.

Script

ে

The vowel of English *pet*, said with the mouth a little more closed than an English speaker expects.

It is written **in front** of its consonant, exactly like ি:

ক + ে → কে — said *ke*

Two signs now stand on the left, and it is worth having a rule for them rather than two facts. **A vowel sign written before the consonant is still spoken after it.** That single sentence covers ি and ে and everything the script will do with a leading mark from here on. It is not a quirk of two letters; it is how the system writes a leading mark at all.

The shape is a single upright stroke with a small hook, and it is easy to write too tall — it should reach the head-line and stop.

Keep an eye on this one. It is going to come back joined to something else, and when it does, both halves will already be yours.

Your turn

- Write it: ে
- Write it: কে
- Read it: ভুমি

Before you move on

Which two signs are written in front of their consonant? (ি and ে.)

And what is true of any sign written in front? (It is **spoken after**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

17.11 কেমন — how, and the six words this chapter gave back

Write the three vowel signs of this chapter and say which way each one faces.

Script

ক + ে + ম + ন → কেমন

- ক with ে in front of it — *ke*
- ম — *mô*
- ন — its inherent vowel worn almost to nothing at the end

kemon — *how*, the word that opens the sentence you have been saying since the third chapter to ask someone how they are.

Nothing new was needed for it. That is the shape of this whole chapter: five pieces added, and six words that were already in the mouth handed over to the eye.

Count what you hold now. Nine pieces came from the first script chapter; five more were added here — ি, ল, ত, ু, ে. Fourteen pieces, and with them:

- নাম — *name*
- আমি — *I*
- লাল — *red*
- তিন — *three*
- তুমি — *you*
- কেমন — *how*

and, without being counted as words of their own, নাক, কি, আসি and কাল.

Three of the five additions were vowel signs, and that ratio is not an accident. The consonants are many and each one buys a little; the vowel signs are few and each one buys a great deal, because every consonant already held can take every sign. Adding a sign multiplies. Adding a letter adds.

Your turn

- *Read it:* নাম আমি লাল তিন তুমি কেমন
- *Read it:* নমস্কার
- *Write it:* কেমন
- *Write it:* তুমি কেমন

Before you move on

How many new pieces did this chapter add? (**Five.**) How many of them were vowel signs? (**Three.**) And why is a vowel sign worth more than a consonant? (Because **every consonant you hold can take it** — it multiplies.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

Chapter 18

The Breath That Is a Letter

Modes: ✍ pen (12) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 12 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read six more Bengali words I already say — কালো, আবার, ভালো, মুখ, সাদা and দুধ — tell a plain consonant from its breathy partner on the page and in the mouth, and say why the o-sign is two signs I already write rather than a new shape.

Milk puts the plain dental and its breathy partner side by side in one three-piece word, then the chapter's six words are read back in one pass with nothing new introduced.

18.1 ো — the o-sign, wrapped around its letter

Read কেমন, then write ে on its own.

Script

The last chapter promised that ে would come back joined to something. Here it is:

ো

Look at it before reading on. On the left is ে. On the right is া. The sign for o is the e-sign and the a-sign, written around one consonant at the same time:

ক + ো → কো — said *ko*

Nothing was memorised for this. Two shapes already in the hand, put on either side of a letter, make a third sound. That is the economy the whole script runs on, and it is why a system with around fifty letters does not need fifty separate strokes to write.

The sound is the *o* of English *tone* without the glide English puts on the end of it. Hold it flat; do not let it slide toward *oo*.

One warning for the eye. Because the sign has a piece on each side, a consonant wearing ো is wider than any letter met so far, and a reader can mistake the right-hand half for a mātrā belonging to the next letter along. It belongs to the one inside.

Your turn

- Write it: ো
- Write it: কো
- Read it: কেমন

Before you move on

What two signs is ো made of? (ে and া.) Which letter does the right-hand half belong to — the one before it or the one inside it? (**The one inside.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.2 কালো — black, read

Write ো, and name the two signs it is made of.

Script

ক + া + ল + ো → কালো

- ক with া after it — *kā*
- ল with ো around it — *lo*

kālo — *black*, the colour that is the same word as Sanskrit *kāla*, “time,” and stands behind both Kālī and Yama.

This is the first word in the book with **two different vowel signs on two consecutive letters**, and it is the moment the eye has to stop scanning

and start parsing. There are three marks after the first ক and only two of them belong together. Work it as the last lesson said: find the consonant, then look around it.

Set it beside the red from the last chapter and the two are nearly twins on the page:

লাল and কালো

Both open with a consonant plus া; both close on ল. What separates them is which letter the ল is and what is hanging on it.

Your turn

- *Read it:* কালো
- *Read it:* লাল
- *Read it:* কেমন
- *Write it:* কালো

Before you move on

Which letter in কালো is wearing the o-sign? (The ল — the second one.) And what else does the same Sanskrit word behind it mean? (Time.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.3 ব — the consonant ba

Read কালো and লাল aloud before adding a new shape.

Script

ব

bô — the *b* of English *bin*, with the lips shut and no puff of air after.

This shape carries the load of the track's whole sound-fingerprint. Sanskrit had a separate *v*, and Bengali does not: the sound collapsed into **b**, and the letter that used to write *v* is now read as this one. That is why Sanskrit *dhanyavāda* is spoken *dhônyobad* in the first chapter, and why a Sanskrit word with a *v* in it will keep turning up in Bengali with a *b*.

So when a word looks like a Sanskrit word you know but has a *b* where you expect a *v*, you have not found a different word. You have found the same one, wearing this letter.

With the mātrā:

ব + া → বা

Your turn

- Write it: ব
- Write it: বা
- Read it: কালো

Before you move on

What Sanskrit sound does ব now do the work of, besides *b*? (*v*.) So if a Sanskrit word you know has a *v* where Bengali has a *b*, is it a different word? (**No** — the same one.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.4 আবার — again, read

Write ব, and say which Sanskrit sound it took over.

Script

আ + ব + া + র → আবার

- আ — standing alone at the front of the word, as it always must
- ব with া — *bā*
- র — *rô*, worn down to almost nothing at the end

ābār — *again*, the word that opens the goodbye from the farewells chapter.

Two things are worth noticing about the shape of the word rather than its meaning.

First, the আ at the front. A vowel at the start of a word has no consonant to hang a sign on, so it uses its own full independent letter. A vowel

anywhere else is a sign. Same sound, two forms, and which one you write is decided entirely by whether there is a consonant to lean on.

Second, look at the two া̃ shapes here — no, look again: there is only one. The first আ contains a vertical stroke that resembles the mātrā, and it is not one. That resemblance is not an accident of the font. The independent letter and the sign are historically the same mark, which is exactly why they look related and exactly why they are easy to confuse.

Your turn

- *Read it:* আবার
- *Read it:* কালো
- *Write it:* আবার

Before you move on

Why does আবার open with the full letter আ and not the sign া̃? (There is **no consonant to lean on** at the start of a word.) And what does the word mean? (*Again.*)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.5 ভ — the consonant bha, the breathy twin

Read আবার, and write ব once from memory.

Script

ভ

bhô — ব with a puff of breath released through it. Not *b* then *h* as two sounds, but one closure opened onto a gust.

The letter for the unaspirated ক made this point about *k* in the last script chapter, and here it is again on the other side of the mouth: **the puff is a letter, not a manner of speaking**. Hold a palm in front of your mouth. Say English *bin*: no air. Now push a breath out through the release. That is this shape.

English has both sounds and treats neither as meaningful — the *b* of *bin* and an emphatic, breathy *b* are the same word said twice. Bengali has two letters, two spellings, and two words.

Look at the shape beside the one it is built from. ব and ভ share their left-hand body; ভ adds a stroke on the right. The script is drawing the relationship the mouth makes, which is a habit worth expecting: aspirated letters often look like their plain partners with something extra.

With the mātrā:

ভ + া → ভা

Your turn

- Write it: ভ
- Write it: ব ভ
- Read it: আবার

Before you move on

Is the puff of breath in ভ a separate sound or part of the letter? (**Part of the letter.**) Does English treat the difference as meaningful? (**No.**) Does Bengali? (**Yes** — two letters, two words.) Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.6 ভালো — good, read

Write ব and ভ one after the other, and say what separates them.

Script

ভ + া + ল + ো → ভালো

- ভ with া — *bhā*, breath and all
- ল with ো around it — *lo*

bhālo — *good, well*. It is the answer to *how are you*; it is the first half of the phrase for liking something; it is the first half of the verb for loving someone. No word in this track turns up in more sentences.

Now put it next to the word from four lessons ago:

কালো — *kālo*, black ভালো — *bhālo*, good

Identical except for the first letter. Both are consonant plus াঁ, then ল wearing োঁ. A learner who can build one has built the other, and a learner who cannot yet tell ক from ভ at a glance has now been handed the exercise that fixes it.

That near-miss is worth taking seriously rather than enjoying. Bengali is full of pairs like this, and the reader who slows down for the first letter is the reader who stops guessing words from their silhouette.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ভালো
- *Read it:* কালো ভালো
- *Write it:* ভালো

Before you move on

What is the only difference on the page between কালো and ভালো? (**The first letter.**) And which of them means *good*? (ভালো.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.7 খ — the consonant kha, the breathy k

Read ভালো, then write ক from memory.

Script

খ

khô — ক with the breath let out through it. The *k* of English *kit*, in fact, which is the breathy one; ক was the *k* of *skip*.

That makes three pairs met so far, and the third is where a pattern earns the name:

- ক plain, খ breathy
- ব plain, ভ breathy

Bengali sorts its consonants into families this way all the way down, and it does it in a fixed order that every Indian script shares — which is why a Bengali dictionary, a Devanagari dictionary and a Tamil dictionary all

run their letters in the same sequence, though the shapes have nothing in common.

Knowing that a plain letter has a breathy partner turns a list of forty shapes into twenty pairs, and pairs are what a hand can hold.

With the u-sign underneath:

$$\text{খ} + \text{ু} \rightarrow \text{খু}$$

Your turn

- Write it: খ
- Write it: ক খ
- Read it: ভালো

Before you move on

Which of ক and খ is the *k* of *kit*? (খ — the breathy one.) And what does knowing about pairs do to a list of forty shapes? (Turns it into **twenty pairs**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.8 মুখ — mouth, read

Write খ, then write ঁ underneath it.

Script

$$\text{ম} + \text{ু} + \text{খ} \rightarrow \text{মুখ}$$

- ম with ঁ hanging under it — *mu*
- খ — the breathy *k*, and at the end of a word its inherent vowel is gone, so what is left is the closure and the puff

mukh — *mouth*, from the chapter on the face. A tatsama: kept whole out of Sanskrit rather than worn down on the way.

The end of this word is where a new reader loses the breath. English speakers finishing a word on *k* stop the air dead; Bengali lets it out. Say *mu*, close on the back of the tongue, and then open. If the last thing a listener hears is air, it was right.

There is a smaller thing worth seeing on the page. Three letters, one sign, and the sign is the only mark below the head-line in the whole word. A Bengali word's information is not spread evenly — most of it rides on the band, and the occasional piece that drops below is doing work the eye must not skip.

Your turn

- *Read it:* মুখ
- *Read it:* ভালো
- *Write it:* মুখ

Before you move on

What happens to the breath at the end of মুখ? (It **comes out** — the letter is the breathy one.) And where is the only mark below the head-line? (Under the **first** letter.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.9 দ — the consonant da

Read মুখ, then write ত and say where the tongue goes for it.

Script

দ

dô — the same tongue position as ত, on the **back of the top front teeth**, with the voice switched on.

So the warning that came with ত applies here without a word changed. English makes its *d* on the ridge behind the teeth; Bengali has a separate letter for that position, and it is a different letter spelling different words. Slide the tongue forward onto enamel.

The pair to hold is not *t* and *d* as English thinks of them. It is:

- ত dental, voice off
- দ dental, voice on

Two settings on one place of articulation. Bengali's consonant grid is built out of exactly these two switches — where the tongue is, and whether the voice is on — plus the breath from the last lesson. Three switches, and most of the inventory falls out of them.

With the mātrā:

দ + া → দা

Your turn

- Write it: দ
- Write it: ত দ
- Read it: মুখ

Before you move on

What is the same about ত and দ? (**Where the tongue goes** — the teeth.) What is different? (**The voice.**) And is an English *d* the same letter? (**No** — it is made further back.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.10 সাদা — white, read

Write দ, and say what separates it from ত.

Script

স + া + দ + া → সাদা

Two consonants, each wearing the same mātrā. As plain a spelling as this book has shown.

shādā — *white*. And notice the first sound: the letter is the *s*-letter, and it is said **sh**. That was the news of the greeting back in the first script chapter, and it has not changed. In Bengali this letter is *sh* far more often than it is *s*, which is the second leg of the track's sound-fingerprint.

Three colours are now readable:

লাল *lāl* — red কালো *kālo* — black সাদা *shādā* — white

White is the one of the three where Bengali and Hindi went different ways: Hindi took a Persian loan for it and Bengali kept its own word, where for red both took the same Persian gem-name. A page of Bengali colour words is a small map of who borrowed what.

Your turn

- *Read it:* সাদা
- *Read it:* লাল কালো সাদা
- *Write it:* সাদা

Before you move on

The first letter of সাদা is written *s*. How is it said? (*sh*.) And which of the three colours is the one Bengali kept where Hindi borrowed? (সাদা — white.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.11 ধ — the consonant dha

Read সাদা, then write দ from memory.

Script

ধ

dhô — দ with the breath let out through it. Voice on, tongue on the teeth, and air after the release.

Set the four dental letters side by side and the grid the last two lessons have been building is visible in one line:

- ত — voice off, no breath
- দ — voice on, no breath
- ধ — voice on, with breath

The fourth cell, voice off and with breath, is a letter this book has not needed yet. It exists, it sits between the first two in every dictionary, and it will arrive when a word calls for it.

That square is the unit. Every place of articulation in the script — teeth, ridge, palate, throat — gets the same four cells in the same order, and the order is over two thousand years old: the Sanskrit grammarians sorted the sounds by where they were made and wrote the list down, and every script descended from that tradition still lists them that way.

With the u-sign:

ধ + ু → ধু

Your turn

- Write it: ধ
- Write it: ত দ ধ
- Read it: সাদা

Before you move on

What two things separate ধ from ত? (**Voice** and **breath**.) How many cells does one place of articulation get? (**Four**.) And who fixed that order? (The **Sanskrit grammarians**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

18.12 দুধ — milk, and the six words this chapter gave back

Write দ and ধ, and say what separates them.

Script

দ + ু + ধ → দুধ

- দ with ু under it — *du*, voice on, no breath
- ধ — voice on, **with** breath, and its own vowel gone at the end of the word

dudh — *milk*. Two letters that a reader half-attending will read as the same shape twice, and the word says them differently: the first closes clean, the second opens onto air. Say it slowly enough to hear the second one leak.

This is the whole point of a script that spells the breath. English writes *d* for both and lets speakers sort it out; Bengali writes the difference down, which is more to learn and less to guess.

Count what this chapter added. Six pieces — ো, ব, ভ, খ, দ, ধ — and six more words handed to the eye:

- কালো — *black*
- আবার — *again*
- ভালো — *good*
- মুখ — *mouth*
- সাদা — *white*
- দুধ — *milk*

Twenty pieces now, twelve words. Four of the six additions were one half of a breathy pair, and the reason the chapter kept returning to that is that it is the one distinction an English-speaking reader has no habit for at all.

Your turn

- *Read it:* কালো আবার ভালো মুখ সাদা দুধ
- *Write it:* দুধ
- *Write it:* ভালো দুধ

Before you move on

Which letter of দুধ lets the breath out? (**The second.**) How many pieces did this chapter add? (**Six.**) And how many words can you read now? (**Twelve.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

Chapter 19

Both Bodies of a Vowel

Modes: ✍ pen (12) ⇌ Hands-free start: none of the 12 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can read six more Bengali words I already say — চা, পরিবার, জল, নীল, ভাই and এক — and say which of a vowel's two forms to write, and why, from whether there is a consonant in front of it.

One is read as a vowel that opens a word with no consonant to carry it, which finally makes visible the claim the numbers chapter could only assert; then all six of the chapter's words are read back with nothing new introduced.

19.1 চ — the consonant cha

Read দুধ aloud, and say which of its two letters lets the breath out.

Script

চ

chô — the *ch* of English *cheap*, with no puff of air after it.

The tongue is somewhere new. Not on the teeth, where ত and দ are made, and not at the back, where ক is: the body of the tongue comes up flat against the **hard roof of the mouth**, a little behind the ridge. English spells that place with two letters, *ch*, because its alphabet has no single sign for it. Bengali has one letter, and — following the square from the last chapter — a breathy partner and two voiced cells to go with it.

That is the fourth place of articulation this book has named: teeth, roof, throat, and lips. The list is not long. **Everything the script writes is one of those places with the voice and breath switches set.**

With the mātrā:

চ + া → চা

That is already a word, and it gets its own lesson next.

Your turn

- Write it: চ
- Write it: চা
- Read it: দুধ

Before you move on

Where in the mouth is চ made? (Against the **roof**, behind the ridge.) How many letters does English need for that sound? (**Two**.) And Bengali? (**One**.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.2 চা — tea, read

Write চ, and say where in the mouth it is made.

Script

চ + া → চা

One consonant and one sign. **chā** — *tea*, and the shortest word this book will ask anyone to read.

It is also a loanword, and the shape of the loan is visible in the sound. Chinese *chá* travelled overland through Persian *čā* and arrived in Bengali as চা. The same leaf travelled by sea, through Hokkien and Dutch traders, and arrived in English as *tea*. One plant, two roads, two words — and which word a language uses tells you which road the leaf took to get there.

Now that the word for milk is also readable, a whole request is on the page:

দুধ চা — *dudh chā*, milk tea

Two words the mouth has had since the tenth chapter, side by side, in script.

Your turn

- *Read it:* চা
- *Read it:* দুধ চা
- *Write it:* চা

Before you move on

How many pieces are in চা? (**Two**.) And why does English say *tea* where Bengali says *chā*? (The word came **by sea**, not overland.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.3 প — the consonant pa

Read চা and দুধ চা aloud before adding a new shape.

Script

প

pô — the *p* of English *spin*, lips shut, no puff of air after the release.

The place is the lips, which is where ব was made too. So the two of them fill two cells of one square:

- প — lips, voice off
- ব — lips, voice on

The English *p* of *pin* is the breathy one and belongs to a different letter, the same trap ক and খ laid in the last chapter. Palm in front of the mouth: *spin* gives no air, and that is this letter.

With the lips named, the map is complete. Every consonant this book has taught is made at one of four places — **lips, teeth, roof, throat** — and every one of them is one of four cells at that place. A reader who has that grid is not memorising forty unrelated shapes. They are filling in a table.

With the mātrā:

প + া → পা

Your turn

- Write it: প
- Write it: প ব
- Read it: চা

Before you move on

Where is প made? (**At the lips.**) Which other letter is made there? (ব.) And what separates them? (**The voice.**)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.4 পরিবার — family, read

Write প, then write ি and say which side of a consonant it goes on.

Script

প + র + ি + ব + া + র → পরিবার

Six pieces — the longest word this book has asked anyone to assemble.

- প — bare, so it carries its own inherent vowel: *pô*
- র with ি in front of it — *ri*
- ব with া — *bā*
- র — *rô*, worn away at the end

pôribār — *family*, the tatsama from the eleventh chapter: *pari-* “around” plus a root meaning “to cover.” What surrounds you.

The first letter is the lesson here. প wears no sign at all, and a reader who has spent two chapters looking for marks will skate over it and say *pri*. It is *pô*. **A consonant with nothing on it is not silent — it is carrying the vowel this whole script is named for.**

That inherent *ô* was the very first thing the script chapters taught, back on ন, and this is the first word long enough to make it matter in the middle of a reading rather than at the start of a letter.

Your turn

- *Read it:* পরিবার
- *Read it:* চা
- *Write it:* পরিবার

Before you move on

What vowel does the bare প carry? (ô.) How many pieces are in পরিবার? (Six.) And what does the word mean? (*Family*.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.5 জ — the consonant ja

Read পরিবার, and say what vowel its bare first letter carries.

Script

জ

jô — the *j* of English *jam*. Same place as চ, the flat of the tongue on the roof of the mouth, with the voice on.

Another two cells of another square, and by now the move should be predictable: meet a consonant, ask where it is made and whether the voice is running, and the letter has a family rather than being a shape on its own.

This letter carries a root worth knowing. Sanskrit *jñā*, “to know,” is spelled with it, and the verbs chapter followed that root out to English **know** and to the *k* that English still writes and no longer says. The Bengali verb for knowing facts opens on this shape.

With the mātrā:

জ + া → জা

Your turn

- *Write it:* জ
- *Write it:* চ জ
- *Read it:* পরিবার

Before you move on

What separates জ from চ? (**The voice.**) And which Sanskrit root for knowing opens on this letter? (*jñā.*)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.6 জল — water, read

Write জ, and say what separates it from চ.

Script

জ + ল → জল

Two letters. **No signs at all.**

jôl — *water*. And the vowel in the middle of it, the ô you can plainly hear, is written nowhere. It is on the page because জ carries it, the way every bare Bengali consonant does.

This is the shortest possible demonstration of the word **abugida**, which the very first script lesson used and this word finally earns. An alphabet writes every vowel. An abugida writes a consonant that already has one, and marks only the vowels that are different. জল is what that looks like when nothing is different.

Set it beside the drink from earlier in this chapter:

চা — one consonant, one sign জল — two consonants, no signs

Both are two syllables in the mouth and neither spells them the way an English reader would expect. The tenth chapter noted that Bengali *eats* its drinks — *jôl khāwā*, “to eat water” — so these two words keep company in more than one way.

Your turn

- *Read it:* জল
- *Read it:* চা জল পরিবার
- *Write it:* জল

Before you move on

How many vowel signs are in জল? (**None.**) So where does the ô come from? (**The consonant carries it.**) And what does the word mean? (**Water.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.7 ী — the second i-sign

Read জল, then write ি and say which side it goes on.

Script

ী

A second sign for **i** — and in modern Bengali speech it sounds **exactly like the first one**.

Sanskrit distinguished a short *i* from a long *ī*, and held words apart by that length alone. Bengali gave the distinction up. The two signs survive because the spellings survive: a word inherited from Sanskrit keeps whichever sign it always had, and the reader learns it word by word rather than by ear.

That is worth stating plainly rather than apologising for. **A script records the history of a language as well as its present**, and the cost of that is a handful of spellings a listener could never have guessed. English readers know the arrangement well — the *k* in *know*, the *gh* in *night*.

The two signs sit on opposite sides:

ি goes **before** its consonant ী goes **after** it, like া

So they are hard to confuse on the page even while being impossible to tell apart in the ear.

ন + ী → নী

Your turn

- Write it: ী
- Write it: নী
- Read it: জল

Before you move on

Do ি and ী sound different in Bengali today? (**No.**) Did they in Sanskrit? (**Yes** — short and long.) And which side does ী go on? (**After** its consonant.)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.8 নীল — blue, read

Write ী, and say which side of its consonant it goes on.

Script

ন + ী + ল → নীল

nīl — *blue*, the colour from Sanskrit *nīla*, the dye that gave English *indigo* its trade and gave the Bengal countryside its indigo plantations.

The sign in the middle is the long one, and that is not a choice a speaker could make. Sanskrit *nīla* had a long *ī*, so Bengali writes ী — even though a Bengali speaker says it no differently from the short sign. The spelling is inherited, and the previous lesson’s point is now something you have to act on rather than agree with.

Four colours are now readable:

লাল — red কালো — black সাদা — white নীল — blue

Of these, blue is the one whose spelling carries a fact about Sanskrit rather than about Bengali. Red is a Persian gem-name; black is the word for time; white is the homegrown one Hindi replaced. Four words, four different histories, and the page shows one of them.

Your turn

- Read it: নীল
- Read it: লাল কালো সাদা নীল
- Write it: নীল

Before you move on

Why does নীল take the long i-sign? (Because Sanskrit *nīla* had a **long i**.) Can a speaker hear the difference? (**No**.) And how many colours can you read now? (**Four**.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.9 ই — the independent i

Read নীল, and say which of the two i-signs it uses.

Script

ই

This is **i** again — the same sound as ি — written as a **letter in its own right** instead of as a mark on somebody else.

You have held a pair like this since the first script chapter without it being named as one. আ is the independent form; া is its sign. Now the same arrangement for *i*: ই is the letter, ি is the sign.

The rule that picks between them was met on আবাব and is worth stating once for every vowel in the script: **a vowel that has a consonant in front of it is written as a sign on that consonant; a vowel that does not is written as its own full letter**. Beginning of a word, or straight after another vowel — those are the places with nothing to lean on.

So ই turns up where a word starts on *i*, and at the end of a word after another vowel, which is where the next lesson will find it.

The shape is unrelated to ি, and that is normal here: a vowel's letter and its sign look nothing alike in Bengali, the way a capital and a lowercase *A* need not look alike in the Latin alphabet.

Your turn

- Write it: ই
- Write it: আ া ই ি
- Read it: নীল

Before you move on

When does a vowel get its own full letter? (When there is **no consonant to lean on**.) Which pair did you already hold without being told? (আ and া.)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.10 ভাই — brother, read

Write **ই**, and say when a vowel gets its own letter instead of a sign.

Script

ভ + া + ই → ভাই

- ভ with া — *bhā*, breath and all
- ই — the full letter, standing on its own

bhāi — *brother*. And the last piece is the rule from the previous lesson doing work in an unexpected place: the *i* here is not at the start of the word, yet it still takes its full letter. Why? Because the thing in front of it is া, a vowel. There is no consonant for a sign to sit on.

“**Nothing to lean on**” does not mean “**start of word**.” It means what it says.

The word itself is worth a line. The eleventh chapter set it out: this is not a cousin of English *brother*, it **is** that word, worn down through Prakrit from the same ancestor — a *tadbhava* rather than a *tatsama*. Its sister বোন, from the same chapter, is not related to English *sister* at all.

Put it beside the good from the last chapter and the shared first letter is obvious:

ভালো and ভাই

Your turn

- *Read it:* ভাই
- *Read it:* ভালো ভাই
- *Write it:* ভাই

Before you move on

Why does ভাই end in the full letter ই rather than the sign? (The piece before it is a **vowel** — nothing to lean on.) And is ভাই a cousin of English *brother*, or the same word? (**The same word.**)
Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.11 এ — the independent e

Read ভাই, and say why its last piece is a full letter.

Script

এ

The vowel of *pet*, written as its own letter. ে is its sign; this is its body. Three pairs are now in hand:

- আ and া
- ই and ি
- এ and ে

The third one is what turns a list of facts into something you can predict. Meeting a new vowel from here on, the question is no longer *what does this do* but *which of its two forms am I looking at* — and the answer is always decided by whether there is a consonant in front of it.

That is the last piece of machinery in this book. Consonants carrying a vowel; signs that replace it; a mark that deletes it; full letters where there is nothing to hang a sign on. Everything else Bengali will ask of a reader is more **shapes**, and the script chapters have said from the beginning that shapes are the cheap part.

Your turn

- Write it: এ
- Write it: আ ই এ
- Read it: ভাই

Before you move on

What is the sign that goes with এ? (ে.) And what decides which of a vowel's two forms you write? (Whether there is a **consonant in front of it.**)

Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

19.12 এক — one, and the words this reader can now take off a page

Write এ and ই, and say what decides when a vowel gets its own letter.

Script

এ + ক → এক

ek — *one*. Two pieces, and the first of them is a vowel standing on its own because a word cannot open on a sign.

The numbers chapter made a remark that could not be checked at the time: it said those five numerals were no good for showing off the inherent ô, because এক opens on an independent vowel. Here is what that meant. There is no consonant at the front of this word to carry a vowel, so there is no inherent vowel to hear. The claim is now something you can see rather than take on trust.

And তিন from the seventeenth chapter is readable too, so two of the five numerals are on the page.

Count the whole holding. Nine pieces came from the first script chapter, five from the seventeenth, six from the eighteenth, and six from this one: চ, প, জ, ি, ই, এ. Twenty-six pieces. And with them, eighteen words:

- নাম *name* · আমি *I* · লাল *red* · তিন *three* · তুমি *you* · কেমন *how*
- কালো *black* · আবার *again* · ভালো *good* · মুখ *mouth* · সাদা *white* · দুধ *milk*
- চা *tea* · পরিবার *family* · জল *water* · নীল *blue* · ভাই *brother* · এক *one*

with নাক, কি, আসি and কাল riding along free.

Every one of them was in the mouth before it was on the page. That order was the whole design: hear a word, use it, and only then be shown what it looks like. A reader who had been handed the alphabet first would have spent twenty-six lessons decoding shapes that meant nothing yet.

Your turn

- *Read it:* চা পরিবার জল নীল ভাই এক
- *Read it:* এক তিন
- *Write it:* এক
- *Write it:* ভালো চা

Before you move on

Why is there no inherent vowel to hear at the start of এক? (It opens on an **independent vowel**, not a consonant.) How many pieces do you hold now? (**Twenty-six**.) And which came first for every one of these words — the sound or the shape? (**The sound**.) Source: Unicode Bengali chart.

The Bengali script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in vowel — and it is ô, not “a.”** ক kô, ন nô, ম mô — written left to right under a connecting top line, like Devanagari but with rounder shapes. This single fact ($a \rightarrow \hat{o}$) is why Sanskrit words sound “Bengali.”
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** কা kâ, কি ki, কী kī, কু ku, কে ke, কো ko. The *i*-signs ি/ী are written *before* the consonant but read *after* it. A *chandrabindu* ঁ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Standalone vowels have their own letters.** A vowel that *starts* a word is written in full: আ ā, অ ô, ই i, উ u, এ e, ও o.

Worth flagging

- **$s \rightarrow$ “sh.”** The letter স (and শ, ষ) is usually pronounced “sh” — আসি is *āshi*, not *āsi*.
- **No separate *v* or *w*.** Bengali has only ব *b*, so Sanskrit *vāda* $\rightarrow$ *bād*, *Vishnu* $\rightarrow$ *Bishnu*.
- **Conjuncts.** A *hasanta* strips a consonant’s vowel so it fuses with the next: স্ + ক $\rightarrow$ স্ক, চ + ছ $\rightarrow$ চ্ছ. Many conjuncts have special shapes you learn as you meet them.

Bengali in the family

Bengali (*Bānglā*) is **Indo-Aryan** — from Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi — and its script descends, with Devanagari, from the old Brahmi writing of India, which is why they share the hanging top line. It is spoken across West Bengal (India) and Bangladesh, and carries an immense literary tradition — Tagore’s poetry, the anthems of two countries. The lessons trace its Sanskrit roots and, where they reach, the wider Indo-European family that also shaped English.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

আসা *āsā*

to come — the verb that never asks whether a man or a woman is speaking
Introduced in Chapter 7.

ভাবা *bhābā*

to think — and the machinery that made a “become” verb into a “think” verb
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ভাই *bhāi*

brother — not borrowed, not a cousin, but the same word as English “brother,”
worn down by six thousand years and two different roads
Introduced in Chapter 11.

ভালো লাগা *bhālo lāgā*

to like — “good sticks to me” — and beside it ভালোবাসা, to love
Introduced in Chapter 9.

ভাত *bhāt*

cooked rice — the meal itself, and a Sanskrit root for “share” that will resurface
two lessons from now in a very different word
Introduced in Chapter 10.

বোঝা *bojhā*

to understand — the third knowing, and the harmony that this time moves the
spelling
Introduced in Chapter 8.

বোন *bon*

sister — not built on the root behind English “sister” at all, but on the very root
that named this book’s rice two lessons ago
Introduced in Chapter 11.

বন্ধু *bôndhu*

friend — a word built openly on “to bind,” and the rare case where Bengali and
English share both the word and the picture behind it
Introduced in Chapter 11.

চা *chā*

tea — a loanword that crossed from China into Bengali overland, and the drink
this chapter’s polite offers run on
Introduced in Chapter 10.

চোখ *chokh*

eye — built on the same Sanskrit root as “to see,” worn down through three
centuries of Bengali spelling before it looked like this
Introduced in Chapter 12.

চশমা *choshma*

glasses — built on the very Persian word the eye lesson once named as its only
cousin
Introduced in Chapter 15.

দয়া করে *doya kore*

please — literally “having done a kindness,” and the noun-plus-করা pattern’s
third demonstration
Introduced in Chapter 13.

দুধ *dudh*

milk — a word whose spelling could ask for a trailing vowel but doesn’t, and a
root whose one secure English cousin is not the word it looks like
Introduced in Chapter 10.

দুঃখিত *dukkhito*

sorry — built on a word two dictionaries explain two different ways, and a prefix
with a real Greek cousin
Introduced in Chapter 13.

দেখা *dækhā*

to see, to look — and the vowel that changes while the spelling stands still
Introduced in Chapter 7.

এক দুই তিন চার পাঁচ *ek dui tin chār pāch*

one to five — and the “two” that kept its Sanskrit vowel
Introduced in Chapter 6.

হওয়া *hōwā*

to be, to become — the second of Bengali’s two be-verbs, and the one that does
what আছে cannot
Introduced in Chapter 7.

হৃদয় *hriday*

heart — a word kept whole from Sanskrit, and the oldest, most secure English
cousin this book has shown you
Introduced in Chapter 12.

জামা *jama*

shirt — a second Persian loan for clothing, the same word behind Hindi’s own
jaamaa
Introduced in Chapter 15.

জানা *jānā*

to know a fact — beside **চেনা**, the second knowing that English merged away
Introduced in Chapter 7.

যাওয়া *jāwā*

to go — and the verb ending that carries how much respect you are paying
Introduced in Chapter 7.

জিজ্ঞাসা করা *jijñāsā kôrā*

to ask — literally “to do a wanting-to-know,” and the door into a thousand verbs
Introduced in Chapter 9.

জল *jôl*

water — the word Chapter 7 already used to say “drink water,” now taught on its own, beside the Bangladesh-register **পানি**
Introduced in Chapter 10.

কালো *kalo*

black — the same word Sanskrit uses for time, and for death
Introduced in Chapter 14.

কাপড় *kapor*

cloth, clothing — a word Sanskrit’s own dictionaries call homegrown, not inherited, and the flapped letter returns
Introduced in Chapter 15.

খাওয়া *khāwā*

to eat — and, in everyday Bengali, to drink as well
Introduced in Chapter 7.

লাল *lal*

red — a jeweler’s word before it was a color word, and the identical Persian loan Hindi already teaches
Introduced in Chapter 14.

লেখা *lekhā*

to write — and the dictionary form that is quietly a noun
Introduced in Chapter 8.

মাফ করবেন *maf korben*

excuse me — the same Persian loan Hindi’s own “sorry” phrase uses, softened here by the future tense rather than a command
Introduced in Chapter 13.

মুখ *mukh*

mouth, face — a word so old that scholars still argue over which language family it belongs to
Introduced in Chapter 12.

নাক *nāk*

nose — the direct cousin of English “nose,” worn down by Bengali’s own sound changes rather than Latin’s or English’s
Introduced in Chapter 12.

নেওয়া *neowā*

to take — and the verb that finishes other verbs
Introduced in Chapter 9.

নীল *nil*

blue — Sanskrit’s word for indigo, one form for every noun it describes
Introduced in Chapter 14.

পড়া *pôṛā*

to read — and the flapped letter Sanskrit never wrote
Introduced in Chapter 8.

পরিবার *pôribār*

family — literally “what surrounds you,” a second word Bengali kept whole from Sanskrit rather than wearing down
Introduced in Chapter 11.

সাহায্য করা *sāhājjo kôrā*

to help — “to go together with,” and the word that finally shows you the inherent vowel
Introduced in Chapter 9.

সাদা *shada*

white — a tadbhava worn down from Sanskrit, and the one color where Bengali and Hindi genuinely parted ways
Introduced in Chapter 14.

শাড়ি *shari*

sari — a Sanskrit word for a strip of cloth that walked, almost unchanged, straight into English
Introduced in Chapter 15.

স্বাগতম *shbagotom*

welcome — “a good coming,” built on the same “hither” prefix already met, and a verb whose PIE root is unusually secure
Introduced in Chapter 13.

সবুজ *shobuj*

green — a second Persian loan, and the chapter’s payoff on all five colors
Introduced in Chapter 14.

আচ্ছা

okay / alright / I see (āchchhā)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

আবার

again
Introduced in Chapter 4.

আবার দেখা হবে

we’ll meet again (goodbye)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

আমি

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

আমি বাংলা বলি

I speak Bengali

Introduced in Chapter 5.

আমার

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

আমার নাম ...

my name is... (with no “is”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো

pleased to meet you (lit. “having made acquaintance, [it] felt good”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

আসি

goodbye, lit. “I’ll come [again]” (āshi)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

কি

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

কাজ করা

to work (lit. “work-do”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

কোনো ব্যাপার না

it’s no matter / no problem / you’re welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

কেমন

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

কাল দেখা হবে

see you tomorrow (and the কাল puzzle)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

তুমি / আপনি

you (familiar / respectful; also তুই intimate)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

তুমি কেমন আছো?

how are you? (familiar)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

তোমার নাম কি?

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

থাকা

to live, to stay, to remain
Introduced in Chapter 5.

দেখা হবে

(we) will meet (lit. “seeing will happen”)
Introduced in Chapter 4.

ধন্যবাদ

thank you (dhônyobad)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

নাম

name
Introduced in Chapter 2.

নমস্কার

hello / goodbye (nômoshkar)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

বলা

to speak, to say
Introduced in Chapter 5.

ভালো

well, good — and the reply “আমি ভালো আছি”
Introduced in Chapter 3.

হ্যাঁ / না

yes / no (hyã / nã)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 10

10.1 জল (*jôl*) — “*water,*” *prised out of a phrase you already know*
Type the Bengali word *jôl*, meaning ‘water’.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 10

10.1 জল (*jôl*) — “*water,*” *prised out of a phrase you already know*

Answer: জল

Also accepted: jôl; jol

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

A

again আবার

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

B

black — the same word Sanskrit uses for time, and for

death কালো (kalo)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

blue — Sanskrit’s word for indigo, one form for every noun it

describes নীল (nil)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

Both Bodies of a Vowel

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 149

brother — not borrowed, not a cousin, but the same word as

English “brother,” worn down by six thousand years and two

different roads ভাই (bhāi)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 77

C

cloth, clothing — a word Sanskrit’s own dictionaries call

homegrown, not inherited, and the flapped letter

returns কাপড় (kapor)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 105

Cloth, Shirt, Sari, and Glasses

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 105

**cooked rice — the meal itself, and a Sanskrit root for “share”
that will resurface two lessons from now in a very different
word ভাত (bhāt)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 69

E

**excuse me — the same Persian loan Hindi’s own “sorry” phrase
uses, softened here by the future tense rather than a
command মাপ করবেন (maf korben)**

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

**eye — built on the same Sanskrit root as “to see,” worn down
through three centuries of Bengali spelling before it looked like
this চোখ (chokh)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

Eye, Mouth, Nose, and Heart

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F

**family — literally “what surrounds you,” a second word Bengali
kept whole from Sanskrit rather than wearing
down পরিবার (pôribār)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 77

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**friend — a word built openly on “to bind,” and the rare case
where Bengali and English share both the word and the picture
behind it বন্ধু (bôndhu)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 77

Friend, Family, Brother, and Sister

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 77

G

glasses — built on the very Persian word the eye lesson once named as its only cousin চশমা (choshma)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 105

goodbye, lit. “I’ll come [again]” (āshi) আসি

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

green — a second Persian loan, and the chapter’s payoff on all five colors সবুজ (shobuj)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

Hanging From the Head-Line, One Piece at a Time

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heart — a word kept whole from Sanskrit, and the oldest, most secure English cousin this book has shown you হৃদয় (hridoy)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

hello / goodbye (nômoshkar) নমস্কার

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

how কেমন

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 17

how are you? (familiar) তুমি কেমন আছো?

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

I

I আমি

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

I speak Bengali আমি বাংলা বলি

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

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it’s no matter / no problem / you’re welcome কোনো ব্যাপার না

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

M

milk — a word whose spelling could ask for a trailing vowel but doesn't, and a root whose one secure English cousin is not the word it looks like দুধ (dudh)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 69

mouth, face — a word so old that scholars still argue over which language family it belongs to মুখ (mukh)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

my আমার

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 9

my name is... (with no “is”) আমার নাম ...

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 9

N

name নাম

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 9

nose — the direct cousin of English “nose,” worn down by Bengali's own sound changes rather than Latin's or

English's নাক (nāk)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 12, p. 83

Numbers One to Five

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 37

O

okay / alright / I see (āchchhā) আচ্ছা

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

one to five — and the “two” that kept its Sanskrit vowel এক দুই
তিন চার পাঁচ (ek dui tin chār pāch)

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 6, p. 37

P

please — literally “having done a kindness,” and the

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explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

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pleased to meet you (lit. “having made acquaintance, [it] felt good”) আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 9

R

red — a jeweler’s word before it was a color word, and the identical Persian loan Hindi already teaches লাল (lal)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

S

sari — a Sanskrit word for a strip of cloth that walked, almost unchanged, straight into English শাড়ি (shari)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 105

see you tomorrow (and the কাল puzzle) কাল দেখা হবে
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

shirt — a second Persian loan for clothing, the same word behind Hindi’s own jaamaa জামা (jama)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 15, p. 105

sister — not built on the root behind English “sister” at all, but on the very root that named this book’s rice two lessons ago বোন (bon)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 77

sorry — built on a word two dictionaries explain two different ways, and a prefix with a real Greek cousin দুঃখিত (dukkhito)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking
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tea — a loanword that crossed from China into Bengali overland, and the drink this chapter’s polite offers run on চা (chā)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 69

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chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 135

The Core Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 41

ে — the e-sign, standing in front

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 31

ি — the i-sign, written before the consonant it is heard after

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121

্ — the mark that DELETES the inherent vowel and fuses two consonants

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111

The Mind and the Page

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 53

ৌ — the o-sign, wrapped around its letter

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135

ী — the second i-sign

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

ু — the u-sign, hanging below the line

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121

া — the vowel sign that replaces the inherent vowel

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111

to ask — literally “to do a wanting-to-know,” and the door into a thousand verbs জিজ্ঞাসা করা (jijñāsā kôrā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 61

to be, to become — the second of Bengali’s two be-verbs, and the one that does what আছে cannot হওয়া (hôwā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to come — the verb that never asks whether a man or a woman is speaking আসা (āsā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to eat — and, in everyday Bengali, to drink as well খাওয়া (khāwā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to go — and the verb ending that carries how much respect you are paying যাওয়া (jāwā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to help — “to go together with,” and the word that finally shows you the inherent vowel সাহায্য করা (sāhājjo kôrā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 61

to know a fact — beside চেনা, the second knowing that English merged away জানা (jānā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to like — “good sticks to me” — and beside it ভালোবাসা, to love ভালো লাগা (bhālo lāgā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 61

to live, to stay, to remain থাকা

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

to read — and the flapped letter Sanskrit never wrote পড়া (pôṛā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 53

to see, to look — and the vowel that changes while the spelling stands still দেখা (dækhā)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 41

to speak, to say বলা

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

to take — and the verb that finishes other verbs নেওয়া (neowā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 9, p. 61

to think — and the machinery that made a “become” verb into a “think” verb ভাবা (bhābā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 53

to understand — the third knowing, and the harmony that this time moves the spelling বোঝা (bojhā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 53

to work (lit. “work-do”) কাজ করা

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 31

to write — and the dictionary form that is quietly a noun লেখা (lekhā)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 8, p. 53

W

water — the word Chapter 7 already used to say “drink water,” now taught on its own, beside the Bangladesh-register

পানি জল (jôl)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 69

we’ll meet again (goodbye) আবার দেখা হবে

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

(we) will meet (lit. “seeing will happen”) দেখা হবে

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 25

welcome — “a good coming,” built on the same “hither” prefix already met, and a verb whose PIE root is unusually

secure স্বাগতম (shbagotom)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 13, p. 89

well, good — and the reply “আমি ভালো আছি” ভালো

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 17

what কি

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 9

what’s your name? তোমার নাম কি?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 9

white — a tadbhava worn down from Sanskrit, and the one color where Bengali and Hindi genuinely parted ways সাদা (shada)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 14, p. 97

Y

yes / no (hyā / nā) হ্যাঁ / না
explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful; also তুই intimate) তুমি / আপনি
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 9

Other

আ — the same vowel standing alone
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111

আবার — again, read
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135

আমি — the word for I, and two more that come free with it
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121

ই — the independent i
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

এ — the independent e
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

এক — one, and the words this reader can now take off a page
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

ক — the consonant ka
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111

কেমন — how, and the six words this chapter gave back
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121

কালো — black, read
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135

খ — the consonant kha, the breathy k
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135

চা — tea, read
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

চ — the consonant cha
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

জ — the consonant ja
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

জল — water, read
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149

- ত — the consonant ta, the dental one**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- তিন — three, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- তুমি — the familiar you, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- দ — the consonant da**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- দুধ — milk, and the six words this chapter gave back**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- ধ — the consonant dha**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- ন — the consonant na**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111
- নাম — a whole word, read, with nothing new in it**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- নমস্কার — seven pieces, all of them already yours**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111
- নীল — blue, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149
- প — the consonant pa**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149
- পরিবার — family, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149
- ব — the consonant ba**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- ভ — the consonant bha, the breathy twin**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- ভাই — brother, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 149
- ভালো — good, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- ম — the consonant ma**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111
- মুখ — mouth, read**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135
- র — the last consonant of the greeting**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111
- ল — the consonant la**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- লাল — red, and the day-word that runs both ways**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 17, p. 121
- স — the consonant that is written s and said sh**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111

সাদা — **white, read**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 135

হ — **the consonant ha**

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 111